

The Language of Non-Institutional Politics and Power

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Abstract

This paper examines the rhetorical style of insurgents, revolutionaries, and activists. Using part-of-speech tagging on a one-million-page corpus, it demonstrates that non-institutional politics is characterized by action-oriented language. Through instrumental variables analysis and the synthetic control method, the project further shows that power shapes the intensity of this language. Calls for community action increase once community resources become legible to the movement organization. Community organizing, rather than past mobilization, is therefore the main channel through which power shapes political rhetoric. The action-language pattern holds across languages, ideologies, alternative specifications, and movement types, while movement-level evidence extends the relationship between latent power and action-language beyond a single organization. More broadly, the paper shows that outsider politics depends on community resources in the absence of institutional access.

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1 Introduction

Non-institutional politics is on the rise. With public trust in government near historic [lows](#), community members are taking action to dismantle the very institutions they have built over decades. This process is coupled with the rise of a new crop of politicians who promise to upend politics with the help of discontented masses. The January 6 attack on the Capitol illustrates the core elements of the story: An outsider to establishment politics with much at stake, movement organizations capable of mobilizing the masses, and community members persuaded by ideas produced and disseminated in an alternative knowledge field.

Dramatic as it might be, none of this is entirely new. Left and right-wing movements have fought one another and existing institutions since the late nineteenth century. Despite their monumental effects in world politics, non-institutional politics as a whole has received scant scholarly attention. Disciplinary divisions are partly to blame. They prevented the study of insurgents, revolutionaries and activists under the same framework. Furthermore, the separation between historical and contemporary analysis has obscured the continuity of non-institutional politics across time. Two consequences followed. First, no comprehensive picture of non-institutional politics has emerged. Second, we have learned very little about the language of these outsiders.

This paper addresses the latter gap and asks why political outsiders—insurgents, revolutionaries, and activists—speak differently from institutional actors. It develops a theory of outsider rhetoric by explaining why non-institutional politics relies on an action-oriented language and its intensity varies across movement organizations. The main argument is that without access to institutional resources, outsiders depend on the community for survival. In response, they develop action-language, a rhetorical style that turns political claims into calls for community action.

The main puzzle of the paper is variation in rhetoric among outsiders. If they share the same survival imperative, why do some movement organizations deploy this rhetoric more intensely than others? The answer is power. Appeals to the community need to stay credible, and they do so when they match the organization’s presence on the ground. Power operates through two channels on the ground: community organizing and past mobilization, which produce latent and realized power respectively. Legibility—information about the community and its resources—is the mechanism through which community organizing links power to rhetoric, enabling movement organizations to calibrate their appeals.

The project relies on seven datasets built from scratch, including roughly one million pages of multilingual political text covering far-left and far-right movements alongside legislative speech. Drawing on one of the largest corpora on non-institutional politics to date, the analysis compares the language of non-institutional and institutional politics through verb density, uses the synthetic control method to estimate the causal effect of power on the rhetoric of movement organizations, and employs instrumental variables analysis to distinguish the effects of latent and realized power. The Turkish case provides the main evidence, with historical U.S. data used for external validation.

The analysis produces five findings. First, political outsiders consistently employ more action-language than actors inside institutional politics. Second, a movement organization’s power increases action-language intensity. Third, community organizing generates this effect by making the community and its resources legible to movement organizations. Fourth, past mobilization does not have the same effect, suggesting that future potential matters more than past performance in shaping rhetoric. Finally, the outsider–insider difference holds across languages, ideologies, organizations, and institutional settings, indicating that action-language is a general feature of non-institutional politics.

The paper contributes to three literatures. For conflict and social movement research, it places language at the center of mobilization efforts and demonstrates that rhetoric is itself a strategic necessity for movement survival. For text analysis, it complements semantic approaches, shows the value of extending text-as-data research to the study of non-institutional politics, and combines computational methods with causal inference. For political science, it reveals that the boundaries of institutional politics shape political communication.

2 Gaps in the study of non-institutional politics

Three major gaps limit the study of non-institutional politics. First, language remains underexamined in conflict and social movement scholarship. Despite valuable contributions to the study of insurgent

groups, revolutionary politics, and social movements, both fields have paid limited attention to the language of these outsiders (Della Porta, 2013; McAdam, Tarrow and Tilly, 2001; Weinstein, 2006). Much of the effort has gone to explaining onset, dynamics, and termination of conflicts and movements. Second, rapid growth of text-as-data research has failed to fill the gap. Substantive treatments have focused primarily on politicians, political parties, and legislatures (Casas, Denny and Wilkerson, 2020; Jung, 2020; Quinn et al., 2010; Vishwanath, 2025). A meta-analysis of 343 articles in political science journals reveals that articles on institutional politics outnumber those on non-institutional politics by roughly seven to one. Third, methodological attention has concentrated on uncovering semantic relations through techniques such as topic modeling and word embeddings (Rheault and Cochrane, 2020; Roberts et al., 2014; Rodriguez and Spiraling, 2022). Consequently, syntax remains underutilized as a way to study political rhetoric, even though rhetorical form reflects actors’ motivations, preferences, and capabilities. A detailed literature review and the accompanying meta-analysis are available in Appendix A.

The paper addresses these gaps by treating language as an outcome, extending text analysis to non-institutional politics, and using syntax to identify outsider rhetoric. To do so, it draws on three areas. The first is computational linguistics (Jurafsky and Martin, 2023). By expanding the sample far beyond what human annotation can cover, machine learning estimates linguistic patterns at scale. Second, the paper joins work that approaches political language via syntax (Jones, 2016; Liu, 2022; Widmann, 2021). Third, it is in conversation with research on non-institutional politics that uses text as data. The focus on rhetoric aligns with studies that explore the determinants of rhetoric in conflict settings (Esberg and Siegel, 2023; Karell and Freedman, 2019; Nielsen, 2020), while complementing a growing literature on political control that examines how institutional actors produce, censor and manipulate political content, while surveilling community members.

The next section develops a two-part theory explaining why exclusion from institutional politics produces action-language and its intensity varies with a movement organization’s power. Appendix B.1 provides a glossary of the main concepts and terms used in the theory. The argument proceeds in five steps: outsiders need community resources; this dependence produces action-language; movement organizations cannot make unlimited demands while remaining credible; ground-level power determines how much they can ask; and community organizing, through legibility, provides a more durable basis for those appeals than past mobilization.

3 A Two-Part Theory on Action-Language and Its Determinants

3.1 Part I: Outsiders use action-language to survive

3.1.1 Institutional politics as a monopoly

Institutional politics is about making community-level decisions based on formal or informal rules of representation (Pitkin, 1967; Levitsky and Ziblatt, 2018; Graham and Svolik, 2020). It operates through designated actors, mechanisms, and venues that clearly define what politics is and how it ought to be practiced. These boundaries have an important consequence: they limit politics to certain forms, while giving exclusive control to institutional actors. Non-institutional politics, then, is a collective attempt by an outsider to challenge this monopoly (Gamson, 1975; Tarrow, 1994). Movements do this by creating new forms of agency and political action in venues that fall outside existing structures. Collectively operating as a movement, these outsiders organize as insurgencies, revolutionary groups or social movement organizations (McCarthy and Zald, 1973; Tilly and Tarrow, 2015).

Movement organizations typically enter politics as outsiders. Starting small, they have limited access to institutional and community resources. With no track record, they enjoy little legitimacy inside the community and have few resources, such as money and personnel, to move forward. On the institutional front, political channels are closed to them, while their messages are blocked, reframed, or misrepresented (Gitlin, 2003).

Given these deficits, outsiders face a constant test of survival. Their exclusion is sustained through legal and moral claims (Althusser, 2024; Manekin and Mitts, 2022; McCann, 2006; Weber, 1978). Revolutionary groups are cast as illegal, insurgent groups as violence-seeking, and others as self-enriching actors without moral principles. Forms of control—counter-propaganda, surveillance, detentions, and

court cases—follow (Davenport, 2015; Hassan, Mattingly and Nugent, 2022; Herman and Chomsky, 1988; Schrecker, 1999; Stanley, 2015). Unless the outsider finds a way to spread its message, gain legitimacy, and secure community resources (McCarthy and Zald, 1973, 1977), it will be thrown into the dustbin of history like many before it.

3.1.2 Movements reach out to community via action-language

The outsider’s main response to these challenges is to reach out directly to the community. Unlike institutional actors, whose political communication largely consists of exchanges among government branches, outsiders’ main focus is always the community itself. As the first order of business, the outsider sets up its own communication channel. Not surprisingly, throughout the 20th century, movement organizations have made a concerted effort to establish their own publications, with journals as the favored form.

Over time, this propaganda effort evolves into an alternative knowledge field with many participants (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983; Wooten and Hoffman, 2017). Attacking existing political beliefs and institutions, organic intellectuals (Gramsci, 1971; Kurzman and Owens, 2002) tied to the movement, offer an alternative interpretation of political reality. They claim that the political order has to change because it is unjust, illegitimate, and weak. United against the establishment and divided from within, this collective effort serves a practical goal: to convince community members to disengage from institutional politics and join movement ranks.

Treating language as communication, movement organizations use speech acts (Austin, 1975; Scanell, 2020) to accomplish these twin goals. They amplify syntactic and semantic properties of text that facilitate action, creating a distinct style that I call action-language. By putting forward a series of claims about what the movement, its opponent, and community members are or are not doing on the ground, this rhetorical style prompts and directs the audience to act (Searle, 1975, 1979).¹ In this respect, action-language is about asking the community to commit its resources, such as labor, time, and sacrifice, to an often risky venture.

Action-language has certain syntactic properties (Figure 1). Most importantly, consistent with the goal of mobilizing community members, it is characterized by extensive use of verbs. This dynamic further informs the type of verbs chosen. First, the need for sustained action means that outsiders emphasize ongoing action. Second, verbs associated with non-routine action will take up more space than they do elsewhere. Third, an outsider will always go beyond a simple call for action and highlight obligation: Community members are expected to join action because it is the right thing to do.

Fourth, verbs emphasize potential. By connecting the latent capabilities of a movement organization to future outcomes, they bolster the promise of potential gains (Amenta et al., 2010; Gamson, 1975). Finally, action-language is opponent-centric. Being the weaker party, an outsider runs a negative campaign against its stronger rival simply because it wants to switch the loyalties of community members away from institutional actors. Divisive rhetoric succeeds in this task by instilling a partisan bias (Iyengar et al., 2019) first and then making the opponent look illegitimate and weak. In that respect, action-language is polarizing by default.

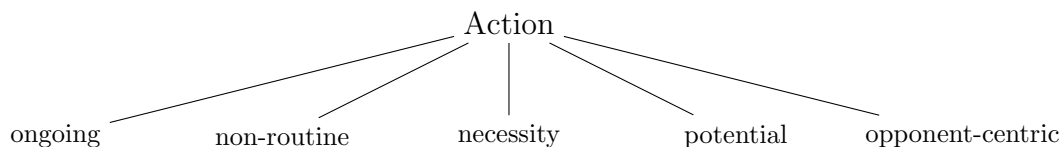


Figure 1: Types of action promoted by action-language

In sum, an outsider’s pitch to the community is a plea for action with two components. The first is taking action against institutional actors. The invitation is about withdrawal and evasion that in turn produce a non-compliant community (Scott, 1985; Johansson and Vinthagen, 2016). The second

¹In speech-act theory parlance, these are illocutionary acts in the form of directives, which concern actions that the speaker intends the listener to perform.

is joining movement-led mobilization. Both address the survival problem of the outsider by providing access to community resources. Collective action builds legitimacy, opens communication channels, and provides recruitment grounds for the movement organization (Oliver, 1993).² In doing so, these actions make it increasingly difficult for institutional actors to eliminate the outsider with the stroke of a pen or through brute force.

3.2 The puzzle

3.2.1 Infinite needs, limited requests

In reality, however, movements and their organizations do not turn up the volume all the time and invite community members to mobilize. They show restraint. Put differently, they don't act like a roving bandit that intends to consume community resources like there is no tomorrow (Olson, 1993). This choice becomes all the more surprising given the fact that they operate with limited options and there are obvious gains from asking for more. Hence, this is the main puzzle of the paper: why does action-language intensity vary over time and across movement organizations when they can simply keep on asking for more from the community?

3.3 Part II: Power determines how intensely movement organizations appeal for action

The main reason is the outsider's power: Current demands from the community will depend on the outsider's prior access to community resources. Drawing on key insights from resource dependence and resource mobilization theories³ (Pfeffer and Salancik, 1978; McCarthy and Zald, 1977), the argument rests on four premises. First, in non-institutional politics, power is the ability of a movement organization to extend its reach into the community and extract the necessary resources. Second, a movement organization's power originates in the community. Third, community resources range from time to human labor but also include emotional goods. Finally, movement organizations rely on community organizing and mobilization to interact with community members, opponents and competitors.

Power shapes action-language intensity because requests have to be consistent with the movement organization's presence on the ground. This consistency makes requests credible (Tomz, 2007) while building community confidence for future action. As explained below, community organizing and mobilization supply the movement organization with power on the ground. When requests exceed that power, though, they can generate audience costs. These downstream consequences⁴ and their effect on the adjustment of rhetoric lie beyond the scope of this paper. The empirical analysis therefore tests whether action-language intensity rises with power, not whether overpromising produces these audience costs.

Power on the ground travels through two channels. These are community organizing (Alinsky, 1971) and mobilization. At the beginning, a movement organization needs to learn about the available community resources and where to find them. Only then can these resources be utilized for organization-specific tasks. These two distinct episodes are community organizing and mobilization, which in turn produce latent and realized power, respectively. While academic research typically documents visible instances of realized power, the history of activism suggests that dissent rests on the longer and more uncertain process of building latent movement power.

3.3.1 Channel 1: Community organizing

Building power starts with legibility (Garfias and Sellars, 2026; Lee and Zhang, 2017). Movement organizations need to learn the ins and outs of the community from which they want to draw support. As a first order of business, they identify groups and sites that are more likely to join their cause, drawing on ideology and adjacent political loyalties. Once a target audience is set, legibility allows a

²But see Olson (1965) on free-riding.

³Both theories suggest that (1) organizations need external resources to survive, (2) these resources are the source of power, and (3) leadership engages in strategic action to deal with environmental constraints and opportunities.

⁴They include loss of trust and reputation (Brutger and Kertzer, 2018; Yue, 2025) for the organization, sunk costs (Arkes and Blumer, 1985; Kahneman and Tversky, 2013) for activists, and reduced engagement from supporters.

movement organization to build group profiles about potential supporters and opponents by observing their actions in space.

Then comes the community outreach. Contact allows an outsider to build a supporter base (sympathizers), and raise awareness about the movement organization (propaganda). The risky nature of non-institutional politics prevents activists from practicing politics in the open. Instead, activists operate with networks of homophily and relational ties, using gender, ethnicity, kinship, and friendship to initiate contacts and build relationships (McPherson, Smith-Lovin and Cook, 2001; Nepstad and Smith, 1999).

Tacit knowledge enters the equation in the final step. Movement organizations tap into local knowledge, what Scott calls *metis* (Scott, 2020). Metis holds the key to community resources. Building on legibility and contact, it helps activists figure out how communities can be mobilized into action by observing, learning, and storing the meaning and experience of political action in the local. As such, latent power is the end product of all activist efforts that take place prior to mobilization. It relies on community organizing to grow and represents future potential to mobilize community members.

3.3.2 Channel 2: Mobilization

If latent power grows by making places and the people inside them visible, realized power comes into life by putting those community resources into use for a movement organization. This mobilization effort includes several forms of collective action that may range from logistical support to active participation. Insurgencies enlist civilians to organize attacks, social movements mobilize community members as protesters, and revolutionary/reactionary groups entrust them with specific tasks as group members. As such, it's the extractive capacity of a movement organization that counts at this stage.

Realized power grows as community members internalize and perform movement roles (Goffman, 1959). Unlike economic and kinship relations, non-institutional politics depends on volunteers who assume risks without guaranteed returns. An insurgent attack illustrates this process: community members maintain communication between teams, provide food and shelter, and supply information about enemy movements. Each task is performed by a distinct group of community members, underscoring the complexity of movement roles that come with varying costs and risks for participants (Wiltfang and McAdam, 1991).

Movement organizations actively promote these roles. Whereas institutional politics primarily approaches community members as voters to be called upon at election time, outsiders portray them as heroes entrusted with a sacred mission. Expectations from community members grow especially when the risks are high. For instance, during armed conflict, community members are expected to reorient their lives to better serve the struggle. As high-profile interpreters of reality, professional revolutionaries, politically-motivated clerics, online influencers, and Q bakers show the way (Gontijo, 2026; Lenin, 1988; Nielsen, 2017). They enforce a disciplinary agenda (Foucault, 1979) to transform community members into full-time activists to survive in a Schmittian world (Schmitt, 2007).

3.3.3 A comparison of two power types

A comparison between latent and realized power can further pinpoint their distinct nature. Latent power relies on community resources that have at least become legible to a movement organization. These resources can be mobilized in the future and therefore point to future potential. Realized power, by contrast, builds off of resources already in the service of the organization. Hence, realized power is a record of (successful) past performance. This distinction creates an important asymmetry in how movement power is observed: we commonly describe a movement as powerful after seeing a protest or attack, even though the capacity that made such action possible was built beforehand.

Realized power comes with an expiration date. Community resources mobilized on one occasion are not guaranteed to remain available for the next. Participation is costly and episodic, and even sympathetic community members may not be willing to fight one battle after the other (Schrecker, 2021). As such, at any given point, a movement organization's realized power is much lower than its latent power inside the community.⁵ A short analytical discussion on power types and their schematic representation are available in Appendix B.2 and Appendix B.3.

⁵The idea here is that mobilization comes out of community organizing. As rare and extreme events in the protest universe, mass protests are exceptions.

3.4 Theoretical expectations and hypotheses

3.4.1 Theoretical expectations

The first expectation is that the language of non-institutional politics is different than the one used by its institutional counterpart. Because outsiders depend on community resources, movement organizations should employ more action-language than institutional actors. At this level of analysis, the theory focuses on the broad distinction between institutional and non-institutional politics, leaving separate expectations across institutional regimes or movement types to another study.

The second expectation is that variation in action-language intensity within non-institutional politics is an outcome of power. Movement organizations adjust their language and manage expectations based on their presence on the ground.

The two remaining hypotheses distinguish between the forms of power on the ground that affect action-language intensity. Hypothesis 2a suggests that movement organizations adjust their requests based on community organizing, which builds latent power by expanding their potential access to community resources. Since this capacity develops gradually and provides a durable basis for future mobilization, latent power should increase action-language intensity. Furthermore, as weaker entities than their opponents, movement organizations do not have much to show in their past and manage expectations based on future potential.

Hypothesis 2b focuses on realized power and past performance. Previous mobilization suggests that community resources have already been activated on behalf of a movement organization and may inform future appeals. The theoretical rationale behind this pathway is that credibility ties past record to future success. Yet, since mobilization is episodic and difficult to sustain, realized power should have a weaker effect on action-language intensity than latent power.

3.4.2 Hypotheses

The theory yields four testable hypotheses.

- Politics

H1 The language of non-institutional politics has an action-orientation.

- Non-institutional politics

H2 Power increases action-language intensity.

- Non-institutional politics / channels of power

H2a Latent power, built through community organizing, increases action-language intensity.

H2b Realized power, produced through past mobilization, has a weaker effect on action-language intensity than latent power.

4 Empirical Setting and Case Selection

Turkey provides an ideal setting to test claims about non-institutional politics. Socialist and ethnic movements dominated non-institutional politics during the Cold War and retained their outsider status throughout the period. These movements included insurgencies, revolutionary groups, and social movement organizations that varied in ideology, methods, legality, size, and power. Despite these differences, they shared limited access to institutional resources and built an alternative knowledge field to reach out directly to the community.

The Turkish case also provides methodological leverage. Two military interventions structure the comparisons between outsiders and institutional actors as well as among movement organizations. The 1960 coup and a new constitution unexpectedly expanded the political space available for mass movement organizing. Accordingly, socialist and ethnic movements grew beyond intellectual circles and

developed stronger ties with community members. The 1980 coup had the opposite effect: Widespread repression dismantled movement organizations, disrupted their communication channels, severed their ties with the community, and compressed the power differences among them.

The post-coup divergence makes the setting especially well suited to the study of power. The coexistence of high- and low-power movement organizations makes it possible to test whether power shapes a movement organization’s rhetoric and through which channels. The Kurdistan Workers’ Party (PKK) emerged from the same field, building a mass ethnic movement and recruiting thousands into its guerrilla force. That rise was anything but preordained: a later intervention by the Syrian state set the PKK’s power trajectory apart.

The supporting evidence comes from right-wing movements in the interwar United States. The premier organization, the Ku Klux Klan, pursued an anti-immigrant, anti-Catholic, and anti-Black platform that campaigned for White Protestant supremacy. It organized and mobilized millions through an elaborate organizational hierarchy, rituals, and activities. At its core, the Klan promised to reimpose a cultural hierarchy without taking issue with class. Hence, the U.S. example stands in stark contrast to the Turkish case. It helps isolate outsider status as a determinant of action-language irrespective of language, ideology, institutional design, and historical period.

5 Data and Measurement

The empirical analysis relies on seven original datasets with textual and non-textual components. Together, they make it possible to compare the language of non-institutional and institutional politics, estimate how action-language responds to movement-organization power, and distinguish between latent and realized power.

5.1 Data

5.1.1 Seven datasets and one million pages of text

The first dataset covers non-institutional politics in Turkey. It contains the digitized text of 300 revolutionary periodicals published between 1945 and 1998, adding up to 8,458 issues and 230,665 pages. Produced by socialist and ethnic movements, these periodicals represent insurgencies, revolutionary groups, and affiliated social movement organizations that varied in size, legal status, audience, strategy, and power. The main analysis draws on the June 1960–November 1998 period, when movement politics acquired a mass character. Because the data are collected at the journal-issue level, they preserve information about organizational ownership, publication location, audience, document length, and publication date. Table 1 reports monthly descriptive statistics for the revolutionary-periodical corpus during the analysis period.

Table 1: Descriptive statistics on revolutionary periodicals, 1960-1998

Variable	min	median	mean	max	sd
verb (%)	9.35	13.63	13.65	16.02	0.89
no. of journals	1	11	11.91	34	7.68
no. of pages	4	433	481.8	1676	329.98
no. of issues	1	16	17.05	56	11.39
ethnic journal (%)	0	7.48	20.79	85.71	24.35
monthly journal (%)	0	66.67	64.30	78.95	21.34
organization journal (%)	0	69.40	65.08	85.71	26.26

Notes. The analysis period spans June 1960–November 1998 (462 months). The table includes 458 monthly observations for all variables except verb density, for which 456 observations are available.

Institutional politics is represented by the near-complete record of sittings held in the Turkish Grand National Assembly over the same period. This second dataset contains 740,789 pages from

8,617 meetings recorded in the official *Tutanak*. The movement and parliamentary corpora therefore provide extensive monthly records of communication produced inside and outside institutional politics within the same political setting.

Two additional textual datasets provide supporting evidence from the interwar United States. The Ku Klux Klan corpus is built from the *Kourier*, the organization’s premier publication, through which its leadership communicated the movement’s official views and activities to followers. Institutional politics is represented by proceedings and debates from the bound edition of *Congressional Record*. Both datasets cover December 1924 through December 1931 and are organized in monthly intervals. Combined, the four textual datasets contain roughly one million pages (1,040,909) and approximately 750 million tokens covering different languages, ideologies, historical periods, and institutional systems.

The remaining datasets support the analysis of power and its channels. The fifth dataset records 3,574 PKK attacks involving civilian or combatant casualties between 1984 and 1998. It includes information about attack dates, locations, targets, and casualties. Limiting the data to attacks with casualties reduces the risk of non-random missingness for less visible insurgent activities such as village visits and logistical operations.

Two datasets supply information about the instruments. The weather dataset records monthly temperatures from 258 stations inside Turkey between 1983 and 1998. The administrative-expansion dataset reports the names and number of provinces and districts in Turkey’s administrative hierarchy for every year between 1944 and 1997.

5.2 Variables

5.2.1 Measuring action-language

Verb density is the main measure of action-language and enters all analyses as the dependent variable. Verbs provide a theoretically grounded measure of action-orientation because they express how political actors portray both existing and alternative courses of action—what they, their opponents, and community members are doing, not doing, or expected to do on the ground. For each month-year, I tag every token with one of the 17 part-of-speech classes in the [Universal Dependencies](#) framework and divide the number of verb tokens by the total number of tagged tokens, expressed as a percentage.

Let $c_{k,ij}$ denote the number of tokens assigned to part-of-speech class k ($k = 1, \dots, 17$, with $k = 1$ the verb class) in all text from month i of year j . Then:

$$\text{verb}_{ij} (\%) = \frac{c_{1,ij}}{\sum_{k=1}^{17} c_{k,ij}} \times 100 \quad (1)$$

The measure is language-agnostic by construction, since Universal Dependencies enforces consistent grammatical annotation across languages. Measuring verbs as a percentage rather than a count also accounts for differences in document length. Verb density captures the central syntactic property of action-language rather than its full conceptual range. The results section evaluates its convergent validity against measures of the other properties identified by the theory, including ongoing action, necessity, potential, and opponent-centered agency.

5.2.2 Measuring movement organization power

The analysis uses one binary and two continuous measures of power. The binary measure is designed to estimate the overall effect of power on action-language intensity. For the synthetic-control analysis, power is operationalized through a treated-versus-synthetic control comparison. The PKK serves as the treated movement organization following the 1984 intervention (external support for guerrilla warfare), while movement organizations that remained low power form the donor pool from which the PKK’s synthetic control was constructed. The data cover 1982–1989 and are aggregated into four-month intervals. This setup holds document type constant because both the treated unit and the donor organizations communicate through revolutionary periodicals. The intervention and donor-pool construction are discussed in the next section.

The first continuous measure captures latent power through legibility, operationalized as district share—the share of unique administrative mentions that are district-level. I calculate district share for

each month-year as the number of unique districts mentioned divided by the sum of unique districts and provinces mentioned in PKK periodicals. Let d_{ij} denote the number of unique districts mentioned in month i of year j , and p_{ij} the number of unique provinces mentioned in the same month-year.

$$\text{district share}_{ij} (\%) = \frac{d_{ij}}{d_{ij} + p_{ij}} \times 100 \quad (2)$$

Districts are administrative units nested in provinces. A greater district share therefore indicates that the movement organization locates communities and their resources with greater geographical precision. Since contact and tacit knowledge are difficult to observe in external communication, the empirical analysis is limited to legibility, the observable first step on which those subsequent activities depend. District share is measured monthly between January 1982 and November 1998.

The second continuous measure captures realized power through PKK attacks. It is calculated as the number of insurgent attacks with casualties in each month between August 1984 and November 1998. Attacks represent realized power because they place community resources into organization-specific use. Conducting an attack requires information, communication, food, shelter, transportation, and other forms of civilian collaboration. The attack count therefore records resources already activated on behalf of the organization rather than resources that may become available in the future.

Together, the binary and continuous measures move from the general relationship between power and rhetoric to its two ground-level channels. The next section introduces the research designs used to compare outsiders and institutional actors, estimate the causal effect of power, and distinguish the effects of latent and realized power.

5.3 Research design

The paper uses three research designs to evaluate the theoretical expectations. The first compares the language of outsiders with that of actors inside institutional politics. The second uses the synthetic control method to estimate whether a movement organization’s power changes the intensity of action-language. The third employs instrumental variables analysis to distinguish the effects of latent and realized power. Each design draws on features of Turkish political history.

5.3.1 Comparing outsiders and institutional actors

The first design tests whether action-language is a general feature of non-institutional politics. It compares monthly verb density in revolutionary periodicals with verb density in proceedings of the Turkish Parliament between June 1960 and November 1998. Socialist and ethnic movements represent non-institutional politics, while parliamentary speech represents institutional politics. The analysis starts in the aftermath of the 1960 coup when movement politics acquired a mass character. Movement organizations expanded beyond small circles gathered around the illegal Turkish Communist Party, established regular publications, and developed ties with the community through political groups, unions, and professional and student associations. Revolutionary periodicals therefore formed part of an alternative knowledge field. At the same time, parliamentary proceedings provide a continuous record of communication among actors operating inside institutional politics.

The comparison holds language, country, and historical setting constant while testing whether outsiders use more action-language than institutional actors. It identifies a systematic empirical difference rather than the causal effect of a treatment. The analysis uses a one-tailed, two-sample t -test with unequal variances to compare mean monthly verb density across the two groups. In [Appendix C](#), I report t -tests under alternative specifications and across subsamples defined by support base (elite or mass), movement identity (socialist or ethnic), and political regime type (democracy or military rule), all of which may condition the verb gap between non-institutional and institutional politics.

5.3.2 Estimating the effect of power

The second design tests whether power increases action-language intensity among movement organizations. The analysis uses the PKK as the treated movement organization and constructs its counterfactual from a donor pool of organizations that remained low power. The empirical leverage comes from a common disruption followed by a sharp divergence in organizational trajectories.

The military coup of September 1980 tried to eliminate all non-institutional politics. Movement organizations were closed, activists were imprisoned or forced into exile, publications were banned, and community ties were severed. The coup did more than halt mobilization: It dismantled much of the organizational infrastructure through which movements had made communities legible, established contacts, and activated resources. By substantially compressing preexisting power differences, the coup therefore created a comparable baseline from which later trajectories can be compared.

Movement organizations’ responses to the coup varied. Some attempted armed resistance, others concentrated on prison activity or propaganda from Europe, and several Kurdish groups explored operating from Syria or Iraq. Regional contacts were therefore not unique to the PKK. What distinguished the PKK was its ability to convert Syrian support into growing ground-level power inside Turkey. The Syrian state provided access to training facilities in Lebanon, border areas from which the organization could enter Turkey, and a safe location for its leadership. This occurred at a time when leaders of other organizations were killed, imprisoned, or forced into exile, and their organizations faced internal dissent or disintegration. These opportunities enabled the PKK to rebuild community ties and prepare for sustained guerrilla warfare while many other movement organizations remained organizationally weak.

The intervention is dated to August 1984, when the PKK launched its first guerrilla attacks. The launch marked the point at which external support became organizationally consequential and the PKK’s power trajectory began to depart from those of its peers. The analysis covers 1982–1989 and aggregates verb density into four-month intervals. This window provides multiple periods before and after the intervention while limiting anticipation effects preceding the initial attacks. The treatment is not defined by armed strategy either. The donor pool includes movement organizations that attempted guerrilla warfare either before or after 1984. Dev-Yol, for example, engaged in armed resistance before the intervention, while TIKKO pursued guerrilla activity afterward. The comparison therefore distinguishes the capacity to build and sustain ground-level power from the mere adoption of armed strategy.

The synthetic control method constructs a weighted counterfactual from low-power movement organizations that approximates the PKK’s pre-treatment verb density and relevant organizational characteristics. The post-treatment difference between the observed PKK and this synthetic counterpart is then the effect of the PKK’s increase in power on its action-language. Inference relies on the quality of pre-treatment fit and on placebo comparisons. The analysis reassigns treatment to each donor organization and evaluates whether any placebo unit exhibits a post-treatment divergence as large as the PKK’s. It also compares post- to pre-treatment mean-squared prediction error, examines sensitivity to two-, four-, and six-month aggregation windows, and tests whether the result depends solely on one donor organization. Detailed donor weights, predictor balance, placebo distributions, and alternative specifications appear in [Appendix D](#).

Close pre-treatment fit is especially important because selection into Syrian support remains a potential concern. Yet the historical process does not reduce neatly to selection on PKK characteristics. The insurgent group chose to accept and exploit an opportunity that some organizations, such as Dev-Yol, refused. A willingness to use violence, however, did not distinguish the PKK: many movement organizations had engaged in violence during the 1970s. Nor does leadership on its own explain the support relationship. Öcalan had no prior ties to the Syrian state, and his strong authority inside the organization does not itself imply a willingness to accept external backing. Moreover, access itself depended partly on Syrian preferences. For instance, organizations such as Kawa and Rizgari did not receive support on terms comparable to those offered to the PKK.

The pre-treatment comparison asks whether preexisting PKK characteristics could independently explain its later rhetoric. If leadership or a propensity for violence directly produced more action-oriented language, the PKK should already have diverged from its synthetic counterpart before August 1984. Instead, the two trajectories closely tracked each other before the intervention. Whatever distinguished the PKK in its relationship with Syria was not sufficient to produce a distinct rhetorical trajectory before the intervention and therefore cannot, by itself, account for the post-treatment divergence.

Coup fatigue helps explain this common pre-treatment pattern. The 1980 coup severed movement organizations’ community ties, produced political apathy, and directed organizations toward internal restructuring.⁶ The rhetorical divergence began only when the PKK converted external support and

⁶The PKK organized its second Party Congress, which helped solidify Öcalan’s position, and established a training

organizational preparation into renewed community involvement. The timing of the intervention also supports the power account since rhetorical change coincided with fresh access to the community resources. In sum, there is not enough ground to suggest that key preexisting PKK characteristics affected rhetoric independently of renewed community access that occurred after the intervention.

5.3.3 Identifying latent power

The synthetic control method estimates the overall effect of power but cannot determine which ground-level channel produces it. The third design uses instrumental variables (IV) analysis to distinguish the effects of latent and realized power. The first IV analysis focuses on latent power, using district share as the focal empirical measure of legibility in PKK periodicals.⁷ Since districts (adm2) are territorial units nested within provinces (adm1), district-level references indicate more granular knowledge and therefore greater legibility.

Yet, a direct estimate of the relationship between district share and action-language may reflect unobserved changes that affect both. Changes in recruitment or the PKK’s publication agenda⁸ could simultaneously produce more district-level references and action-oriented rhetoric. To address unobserved confounding, the analysis therefore requires variation in district share that originates outside the movement organization. Administrative expansion provides such variation. By dividing provinces into smaller territorial and population units, this policy increased the administrative resolution at which communities and their resources could be located, making district-level references more likely.

The relevance of the instrument follows from the construction of the district-share measure. While the number of provinces remained relatively stable, administrative expansion added 277 districts in a matter of sixteen years, increasing the likelihood that an administrative reference would be at district-level. A change-point analysis identifies 1990 as the year of principal shift, when the number of districts increased from 695 to 828. The instrument therefore takes the value of one after this expansion and zero beforehand.

The origins of the administrative-expansion instrument support the exclusion restriction. The expansion around 1990 was driven by electoral calculations. Facing declining support, the governing Motherland Party created new districts to promise local services before the next election. Most of this expansion occurred outside the core areas of insurgent activity.⁹ The creation of new districts did not provide the PKK with additional resources or organizational access. Nor is there a direct reason for it to alter verb use in insurgent publications. Its proposed effect on rhetoric therefore operates through the greater administrative precision with which the PKK could locate the community and its resources.

While the exclusion restriction cannot be tested directly, the analysis examines whether administrative expansion is associated with observed alternative pathways to verb density. First, I conduct a falsification test in an off-path, zero-first-stage population. This test focuses on newly created districts in provinces with marginal Kurdish populations, where administrative expansion should not increase the PKK’s legibility of the community. If off-path expansion predicted verb density despite failing to move the legibility measure, it would raise concern that administrative expansion affects rhetoric through a pathway unrelated to legibility.

Second, I replace verb density with determiner share in a negative-control outcome test. Since determiners are not part of the theory of action-language, administrative expansion should not predict determiner share unless it is capturing broader changes in part-of-speech distributions. Finally, I examine observed alternative mediators. The concern is that administrative expansion may affect verb density by broadening the PKK’s geographic reach across districts, rather than by increasing the relative precision of its administrative references. In this alternative pathway, new districts would lead the organization to mention a larger number of districts overall, and that wider territorial coverage—not

camp in Lebanon for hundreds of militants.

⁷The latent-power models control for other patterns in administrative mentions—district coverage, attention to major cities, concentration among the most frequently mentioned administrative units, and the frequency of administrative mentions—to isolate district share as the focal operationalization of legibility.

⁸Turnover in the named editor may not capture shifts in the publication agenda. Under Turkish press law, editors were legally responsible for published content, prompting movement organizations to assign the position to members with clean legal records.

⁹Within the conflict zone, security-driven administrative changes took a different form. They primarily reassigned existing districts to different provinces or upgraded a small number of districts to provinces. These changes neither increased the number of districts substantially nor materially increased district share.

district share as a measure of legibility—would drive action-language intensity. I therefore condition on district coverage in the main IV model, examine whether administrative expansion is associated with district coverage, and re-estimate the model without district coverage. The tests and their results are presented in Section 6.1.3 and Appendix E.4.

The IV model uses monthly observations from January 1982 through November 1998 and estimates a two-stage least squares specification with robust standard errors and time fixed effects. The first stage uses administrative expansion to predict district share, accounting for other patterns in administrative mentions and document volume. The second stage estimates whether instrumented district share predicts verb density in the following month. Lagging the outcome preserves the theoretical sequence in which greater legibility allows a movement organization to calibrate its subsequent appeals to the community.

5.3.4 Identifying realized power

The second IV analysis focuses on realized power, measured through PKK attacks with casualties. As described in Section 5.2, attacks place community resources in organization-specific use and therefore record resources already activated rather than resources that may become available. The design asks whether past mobilization raises subsequent action-language intensity, and Hypothesis 2b predicts a weaker effect than latent power.

A direct estimate of the relationship between attacks and action-language may reflect unobserved changes that affect both. Changes in recruitment, government operations, or public attention could simultaneously increase attacks and produce more action-oriented rhetoric. To isolate the effect of realized power on rhetoric, the analysis exploits temperature-driven changes in attacks that are independent of the PKK’s strategic decisions about when to attack. Hotter-than-usual conditions increase the feasibility of insurgent operations but should not directly alter verb use in PKK periodicals.

The instrument is constructed from monthly temperature observations recorded by 258 weather stations across Turkey. Temperature deviation measures the difference between observed temperature and the long-term average for the same month. The instrument takes the value of one when this deviation is positive and zero otherwise. Using deviations rather than absolute temperature distinguishes unusually warm conditions from recurring seasonal patterns. Details on the construction of the measure appear in [Appendix G.2](#).

The exclusion restriction assumes that hotter-than-usual temperatures affect action-language only through their effect on attacks. Temperature has no evident theoretical connection to verb use in insurgent publications, given the fact that the journals were published far from the conflict zone. The model controls for attention to the insurgency in the Turkish and European press and discussion of the Kurdish Question in the European Parliament, since changes in domestic and international salience could affect both attacks and rhetoric. Finally, season and year fixed effects account for recurring seasonal patterns and broader temporal changes.

The IV model uses monthly observations from August 1984 through November 1998 and estimates a two-stage least squares specification with season and year fixed effects. The first stage uses temperature deviation to predict PKK attacks with casualties. The second stage estimates whether instrumented attacks predict verb density in subsequent months. Alternative specifications examine effects from one to five months after mobilization to allow for delayed rhetorical responses. Full specifications, first-stage diagnostics, and alternative temporal models appear in [Appendix G.3](#).

6 Results and Validity

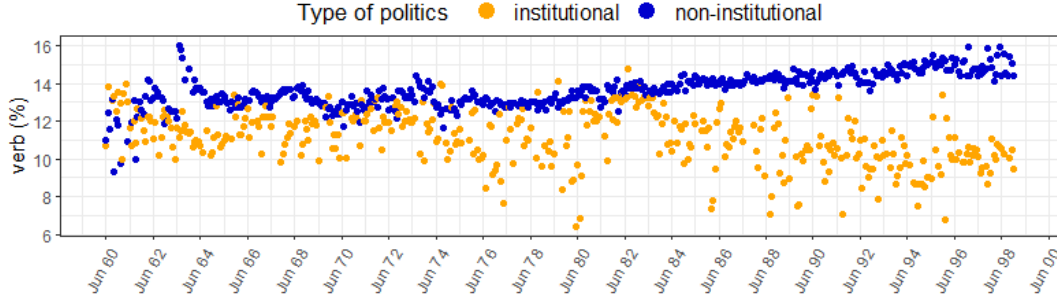
6.1 Main results

The results follow the theoretical sequence. I first present evidence that outsiders use more action-language than actors inside institutional politics. I then show that organizational power increases action-language intensity among movement organizations. The remaining analyses distinguish between latent and realized power, with the evidence pointing to community organizing, measured through legibility, rather than past mobilization as the main channel.

6.1.1 Outsiders use more verbs than institutional actors

Political outsiders use more verbs than actors inside institutional politics. Between June 1960 and November 1998, mean monthly verb density is 13.68 percent in the non-institutional corpus and 11.11 percent in the parliamentary corpus. This amounts to a difference of 2.57 percentage points. Hence, verb density is 23.1 percent higher in movement periodicals than in parliamentary proceedings. Figure 2 shows that this difference is not driven by a small number of outlying months. Across nearly four decades, the monthly series for non-institutional politics remains consistently above that of institutional politics, with a visible separation around 13 percent.

Figure 2: A comparison of political corpora



Notes: The data cover June 1960- November 1998. Socialist and ethnic corpora come from periodicals and together represent non-institutional politics. Sitzings of the Turkish parliament stand for institutional politics.

A one-tailed, two-sample *t*-test with unequal variances confirms that the difference is statistically significant. The test returns a *t*-statistic of 29.63 with 668 degrees of freedom and a *p*-value below 0.001. The lower bound of the 95 percent one-sided confidence interval is 2.33 percentage points. The evidence therefore indicates that the population mean for verb density in non-institutional politics is at least 2.33 percentage points higher than its institutional counterpart.

The result is not sensitive to alternative test specifications or sample restrictions. Two-sided tests, alternative assumptions about variance and dependence, and restrictions based on document size produce substantively similar estimates. The verb gap also persists across socialist and ethnic movements and during periods when movements had either elite or mass support. The only exception is the ethnic movement under military rule with limited support.¹⁰ Detailed estimates appear in [Appendix C](#).

The comparison pairs movement periodicals with parliamentary speech. These genres do not exist independently of actors' position in the political universe. They are produced within distinct political fields, each with its own communicative practices and linguistic style. Outsiders establish revolutionary periodicals as part of an alternative knowledge field because they lack access to institutional resources, while parliamentary actors speak through the legislature because they represent political order and its institutions. Genre is therefore one of the forms through which position relative to the boundaries of institutional politics is expressed, not a separable source of bias.

Furthermore, to the extent that parliamentary proceedings contain spontaneous speech, the movement-legislature comparison is likely to underestimate the verb gap because speech is more action-oriented than written text.¹¹ The speech-writing difference therefore cannot explain the higher verb density of movement texts either. Its expected effect runs in the opposite direction. Had politicians relied entirely on prepared written texts, the gap would likely have been larger. The comparison therefore identifies the overall linguistic difference associated with actors' positions relative to the boundaries of institutional politics, including the communicative forms those positions produce. Taken together,

¹⁰As a double-challenger, military rule suppresses both institutional and non-institutional politics. It restructures politics and weakens movement organizations' ties to the community. In doing so, military rule creates opposite effects on the rhetoric of institutional and non-institutional political actors that reduce the action-language gap between the two.

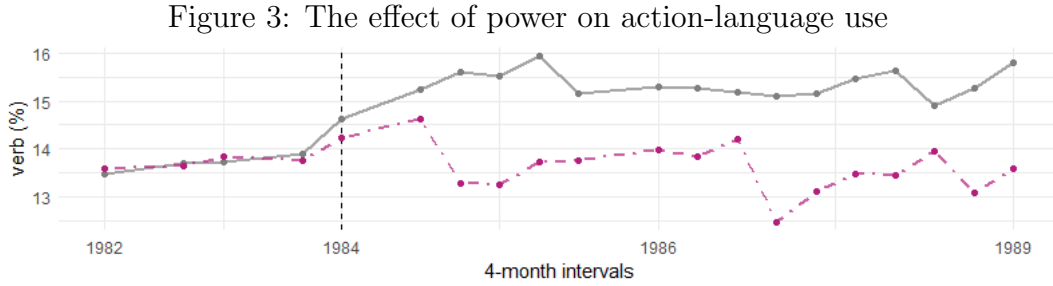
¹¹Spoken language tends to rely more heavily on verbs and clause sequences, whereas written language favors nominalization and greater lexical density, with a higher proportion of information-packed nouns and adjectives.

these findings support Hypothesis 1: the language of non-institutional politics has a stronger action-orientation than the language used inside institutional politics.

The next analysis turns to a sharper within-genre test by comparing only movement periodicals and asking whether action-language varies with power among movement organizations.

6.1.2 Power increases action-language intensity among movement organizations

Figure 3 compares the PKK’s observed verb density with the counterfactual produced by the synthetic control method. Two patterns stand out. Before August 1984, the two series track each other closely. After the intervention, they diverge: verb density rises for the PKK but remains comparatively stable below 14 percent in its synthetic counterpart. The pretreatment covariates are reported in [Appendix D.2](#) and the balance table in [Appendix D.4](#).



Notes: Dashed line denotes the launch of guerrilla warfare by the PKK on August 15, 1984. Time series data cover the 1982-1989 period. The data are aggregated into 4-month intervals with certain months missing because of incomplete data and potential anticipation effects before the initial attacks. The PKK is the treated unit, and six other organizations form the donor pool from which the synthetic control is constructed. *Verb (%)* for each organization is calculated from all its journals published within each interval.

During the pretreatment period, mean verb density is 13.88 percent for the PKK and 13.80 percent for the synthetic PKK. In the post-treatment period, the corresponding values are 15.37 and 13.58 percent. After the PKK’s power trajectory diverged from those of other movement organizations, its verb density was 1.78 percentage points higher than it would otherwise have been had it remained a low-power organization. The estimate for the average treatment effect on the treated may be conservative if the PKK’s rise influenced the rhetoric of donor organizations. In particular, a post-treatment increase among small Kurdish organizations would raise the synthetic counterfactual and thereby narrow the estimated gap. The treatment-effect estimates appear in [Appendix D.3](#).

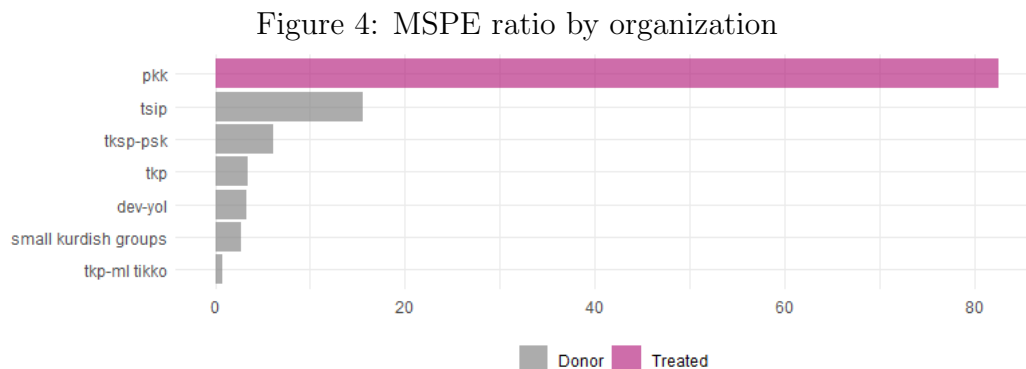
It is important to note that the analysis holds text type constant, and the donor pool consists of organizations that shared a similar vision and audience with the PKK. A separate concern is whether the post-treatment divergence merely reflects the adoption of guerrilla strategy. The donor pool includes organizations that engaged in armed activity before or after the PKK’s intervention but did not develop a comparable rhetorical trajectory. What distinguishes the PKK is its ability to convert external support into expanding and sustained power on the ground. The full donor pool and its organizational characteristics are reported in [Appendix D.1](#).

The estimate is stable across alternative temporal aggregations. The two- and six-month specifications produce substantively similar treatment effects. The same two donor units—Dev-Yol and the small Kurdish organizations—continue to provide most of the synthetic-control weight, and the principal predictors retain similar weights across the alternative specifications. Their persistent weight is substantively meaningful because they most closely resemble the PKK during the pretreatment period. Treatment effects under alternative intervals are in [Appendix D.3](#), while the corresponding donor and predictor weights appear in [Appendix D.5](#).

Placebo tests provide additional evidence that the observed divergence is specific to the PKK. Reassigning treatment to each donor organization produces no comparable post-treatment increase in verb density. This remains true when the comparison is restricted to donor organizations with pretreatment fit comparable to that of the PKK. The donor-placebo results are reported in [Appendix D.4](#).

The ratio of post-treatment to pretreatment mean-squared prediction error (MSPE)¹² supports the same conclusion. Figure 4 shows that the PKK’s MSPE ratio ranks first and is more than five times as large as that of the next-highest donor organization. The complete MSPE ratios appear in [Appendix D.6](#). The low pretreatment MSPE shows that the synthetic control closely reproduces the PKK before the intervention, while the much larger post-treatment error records the subsequent divergence.

Synthetic-control inference relies on the treated unit’s rank within the placebo distribution. Although the limited number of donor organizations prevents significance testing based on rank, the placebo distribution suggests that the MSPE ratio is unlikely to have a value as extreme as the treated unit had there been no treatment. Finally, [Appendix D.7](#) shows that the ratio between the highest and second-highest MSPE ratios remains above five across alternative temporal aggregations—approximately twice the corresponding ratio reported by benchmark studies ([Abadie, Diamond and Hainmueller, 2010, 2015](#)) using the same method.



Notes: MSPE ratio compares MSPE values from post-treatment to those coming from pre-treatment. X-axis represents the quantity of interest.

The synthetic-control evidence therefore supports Hypothesis 2. An increase in a movement organization’s power leads it to intensify its action-language.

6.1.3 Community organizing produces additional verb use through legibility

The preceding analysis linked power to rising action-language intensity. The IV analysis now asks whether community organizing produces this effect through legibility. The first-stage results show that administrative expansion increased legibility, measured as the share of unique administrative mentions that are district-level, by 5.78 percentage points. The weak-instrument F-statistic is 41.81, indicating that administrative expansion strongly predicts the legibility measure. The complete first-stage results appear in [Table E3](#), Appendix E.

The second-stage results¹³ with robust standard errors show that instrumented district share raises action-language intensity in the following month. A one-percentage-point increase in the instrumented legibility measure produces a 0.13-percentage-point increase in verb density and this result is statistically significant. Moving district share from its first quartile (56.60) to its median (65.75) corresponds to an increase of more than one percentage point in predicted verb density. Hence, as district share increases, so does verb use the next month, indicating that the PKK subsequently makes more intensive appeals for community action. The complete second-stage results appear in [Table E4](#), Appendix E.

This result connects community organizing to rhetoric through legibility. District-level knowledge allows the movement organization to locate community activity more precisely and learn who is doing what on the ground. It serves as a field survey of community members and activists and provides the information needed to develop profiles of potential supporters and opponents. By making the

¹²MSPE is the mean squared difference between the observed values of the treated unit and those of its synthetic counterpart.

¹³The model is estimated with the `ivreg` function in R, which implements two-stage least squares. A manually estimated second-stage regression produces incorrect standard errors.

community and its resources more legible, community organizing increases the latent power of the movement organization and gives it a firmer basis for calibrating credible requests for action.

The paper performs three exclusion-restriction checks to see whether the administrative-expansion instrument affects verb density through alternative pathways unrelated to legibility. First, a falsification test examines off-path administrative expansion. I construct a placebo instrument from newly created districts in 13 provinces where the Kurdish-speaking population is below 2 percent. These districts should not generate added legibility for the PKK. Consistent with this expectation, off-path administrative expansion predicts neither district share ($p = 0.38$) nor verb density ($p = 0.28$).

Second, I replace verb density with determiner share, a part-of-speech category outside the theory of action-language. This negative-control outcome test finds little evidence that the instrument captures broader shifts in part-of-speech distributions. Finally, the analysis turns to spatial coverage of district mentions as a viable alternative pathway connecting administrative expansion to rhetoric. If administrative expansion increases the number of unique districts mentioned, broader territorial coverage rather than the relative precision of administrative references could account for the relationship with verb density. I therefore condition on district coverage in the main IV model and re-estimate the model without it. The IV result remains positive and statistically significant when I condition on district coverage or drop it from the model. Complementary analyses also provide little evidence that administrative expansion itself broadens district coverage. The result therefore points to greater administrative resolution rather than broader geographic reach as the relevant dimension of legibility. Full results are available in [Appendix E.4](#).

Finally, local regression shows diminishing returns to legibility. Predicted verb density rises most sharply before unique district mentions become as prevalent as province mentions. As the ratio of district to province mentions reaches 2, the increase in predicted verb density begins to plateau. After that, the rate of change in verb density slows down, while remaining positive. In sum, initial gains in legibility therefore generate the largest rhetorical response, while further gains produce smaller returns. The local-regression results appear in [Figure E2](#), Appendix E.5.

Taken together, these results are consistent with Hypothesis 2a. Community organizing increases action-language intensity by making the community and its resources more legible to the movement organization.

6.1.4 Beyond the PKK: movement-level replication

The above analysis showed that greater legibility increased subsequent action-language use for the PKK. A remaining question is whether this relationship holds beyond the insurgent group. This discussion addresses that concern by replicating the same instrumental-variables design at the movement level.¹⁴

The movement-level analysis draws on the full Turkish non-institutional politics corpus for 1945-1998. Previously used to establish the outsider-insider language difference, the corpus contains 230,665 pages from 8,458 issues of 300 periodicals and covers a substantial portion of the revolutionary-periodical universe. The data are aggregated at the month-year level ($n=574$). The dependent variable is verb density (%), while district share and the remaining variables follow the original latent-power specification.

The results replicate the organization-level finding. A one-percentage-point increase in district share raises verb density by 0.25 percentage points in the following month. The estimated effects are positive and statistically significant in both the PKK and movement-level analyses, and their 95% confidence intervals are not disjoint: (0.08, 0.18) for the PKK analysis and (0.17, 0.33) for the movement-level analysis. Thus, as legibility increases, so do calls for action across the wider field of non-institutional politics. As such, the relationship is neither unique to the PKK nor limited to insurgent organizations.

The first stage results are strong. Administrative expansion increases district share by 5.27 percentage points, and the weak-instrument F-statistic exceeds 10. The model explains nearly half of the variation in the endogenous variable (adjusted $R^2 = 0.47$). Finally, the [local-regression plot](#) reproduces the diminishing returns pattern observed for the PKK: the largest expected increases in verb density occur before district mentions equal province mentions, corresponding to a district share of 50 percent. Full first- and second-stage results appear in [Appendix F.1](#).

¹⁴The instrument takes the value of 1 beginning in 1987 rather than 1990 because the change-detection algorithm identifies an earlier increase in the number of districts when applied to the dataset covering half a century.

6.1.5 Mobilization not so much

The final question is whether realized power has a similar effect on action-language intensity. Hypothesis 2b expects past mobilization to matter less than community organizing because resources mobilized on one occasion may not remain available for the next. The analysis tests this claim using PKK attacks as a measure of realized power.

The first-stage results show that hotter-than-usual conditions increase attacks. Moving the temperature deviation instrument from zero to one corresponds to a 9.1 percent increase in the expected monthly attack count. An OLS diagnostic using the same covariates returns an F-statistic of 11.7, indicating that the instrument is not weak. Variable definitions and summary statistics appear in [Appendix G.1](#), the construction of the temperature instrument in [Appendix G.2](#), and the complete first-stage results in [Appendix G.3](#).

The second stage, however, provides no evidence that instrumented attacks increase action-language intensity in the following month ($p = 0.57$). The result remains null when verb density is measured one to five months later, indicating that the absence of an immediate effect does not conceal a delayed rhetorical response. The complete second-stage estimates appear in [Appendix G.3](#).

This null result is substantively important. Political violence is the most distinctive type of action for insurgencies, and attacks require civilian collaboration. They therefore provide an observable measure of community resources already mobilized on behalf of the movement organization. Yet, unlike legibility, this past use of community resources does not lead the PKK to make more appeals for subsequent action. One reason is the volatile nature of attack counts. High attack counts appear in temporal clusters, including short-lived peaks, and are preceded and followed by more limited activity. This pattern does not reflect the gradual evolution of community organizing, where change takes place slowly. The empirical distribution of attacks reflects this volatility: with an average of 20 attacks per month, attacks jumped to 199 in August 1993 before declining to 48 in the same month the following year. Hence, past mobilization does not provide a durable basis for calibrating future requests.

These results are consistent with Hypothesis 2b. Unlike latent power, realized power is not statistically associated with subsequent verb density. Movement organizations therefore appear to ground their appeals in future potential rather than past performance.

6.2 Validation of action-language

6.2.1 Measurement validity

The paper employs verb density—a computer-generated measure derived from supervised part-of-speech tagging—as its dependent variable. It is therefore important to assess whether differential tagging error drives the estimated outsider-insider difference. Two features of the corpus make this concern relevant. First, since movement periodicals were produced under resource constraints and legal pressure, their print and consequently OCR quality may be lower than that of official parliamentary publications. Second, the composition of the movement corpus changed after the 1980 military coup. Movement periodicals were increasingly published abroad, while ethnic movement publications became more prominent.

To evaluate differential tagger error, I construct human-coded validation samples for the movement and parliamentary corpora. Within each corpus, I divide the data into two temporal blocks separated by the 1980 military coup. From each block, I randomly sample 75 distinct month-years and then randomly select one sentence from each sampled month-year. This yields 150 sentences per corpus. A human coder then classified every token in these sentences as either a verb or a non-verb, using the complete sentence as context and without access to the corresponding UDPIPE¹⁵ classification. This procedure produced 2,814 validated tokens from movement periodicals and 2,525 from parliamentary sittings. To reduce human annotation error, the coding protocol was applied in two complete rounds. Only then were the human and automated classifications compared to calculate the confusion matrices and error rates.

¹⁵UDPIPE is the R package that does the POS tagging based on the [IMST-UD](#) treebank. The annotated corpus contains 5,635 sentences and 56,422 tokens.

Table 2: Hand-coded validation of verb classification

	Movement	Parliament	Difference
Hand-coded tokens	2,814	2,525	–
Human-coded verb tokens	328	256	–
False positives, n (%)	48 (1.93)	62 (2.73)	–
False negatives, n (%)	47 (14.33)	24 (9.38)	–
Observed verb density (%)	13.68	11.11	2.57
Error-corrected verb density (%)	14.03	9.53	4.50

Notes. False-positive percentages are calculated among human-coded non-verbs; false-negative percentages are calculated among human-coded verbs. Error-corrected verb density is calculated as $VD_{\text{corrected}} = (VD_{\text{UDPIPE}} - \text{FPR}) / (1 - \text{FPR} - \text{FNR})$, where VD_{UDPIPE} denotes the original UDPIPE density. The verb density difference is movement minus Parliament, in percentage points.

The validation point estimates suggest different error profiles across the two corpora, and correcting for the estimated errors expands the observed movement–Parliament gap. Tagger’s false-positive rate is higher for parliament transcripts than movement periodicals (2.73 versus 1.93 percent), meaning that it incorrectly adds verbs more often to the Parliament corpus. Conversely, tagger’s false-negative rate is higher in movement texts (14.33 versus 9.38 percent), meaning that it misses a larger share of human-coded verbs in movement periodicals. Applying the corpus-specific error rates increases the estimated verb density of movement periodicals from 13.68 to 14.03 percent and reduces the Parliamentary estimate from 11.11 to 9.53 percent. The corrected difference is therefore 4.50 percentage points, compared with the original difference of 2.57 percentage points. The estimated differential in POS-tagging error does not generate the observed verb-density gap; instead, it causes the original estimate to understate it.

To quantify uncertainty, I conduct a stratified sentence-clustered bootstrap that resamples sentences within each corpus–temporal-block stratum 10,000 times. The 95% confidence intervals for the cross-corpus differences in false-positive and false-negative rates include zero. Thus, the point-estimate differences in tagging errors are not statistically distinguishable. Crucially, the corrected movement–Parliament difference remains positive across the bootstrap distribution: 4.50 pp (95% CI: 3.26–5.79). Thus, accounting for uncertainty in the validation error rates does not alter the main conclusion. POS-tagging error cannot account for the observed verb-density gap. [Appendix H](#) reports the full confusion matrices, precision and recall, temporal-block results¹⁶, and bootstrap estimates.

6.2.2 Construct validity

This subsection validates action-language via convergent validity. If other measures of the same construct are highly correlated with the original measure, one can be more confident that the original measure represents the concept in question. Hypothesis testing with alternative measures can then provide reassurance that the findings are robust to different proxies, less likely to be driven by measurement error specific to the original measure, and consistent with the concept’s scope conditions.

The validation exercise is conducted with verbs that highlight potential, necessity, sustained and non-routine action. This pro-mobilization rhetoric claims that the movement promises a better future, participation is morally necessary, and political action requires sustained engagement through new forms of activity. Since non-institutional actors are at a great disadvantage in commanding the loyalties of community members, the final dimension of action-language is its opponent-centric nature. In addition to issuing pro-mobilization calls, outsiders have to convince community members to detach themselves from the opponent. This negative campaigning requires constant reminders to audiences about the wrongful actions of the other side.

A pre-trained language model for Turkish extracts the relevant grammatical features from verbs along these dimensions.¹⁷ Unlike verb density, which is constructed from part-of-speech tags, these

¹⁶Consistent with expectations, the tagger had a lower false-negative rate in the post-1980 block, although the difference between the two blocks is not statistically significant.

¹⁷Mood and aspect information are available for all verbs, while person is available for 57 percent of verbs. The selected mood categories—potential and necessity—account for roughly 4 percent of verbs, while the selected aspect categories—habitual and progressive—account for approximately 23 percent.

indicators rely on inflectional features extracted with dependency parsing. Universal Dependencies distinguishes 19 possible values for mood, five for aspect, and three for person.

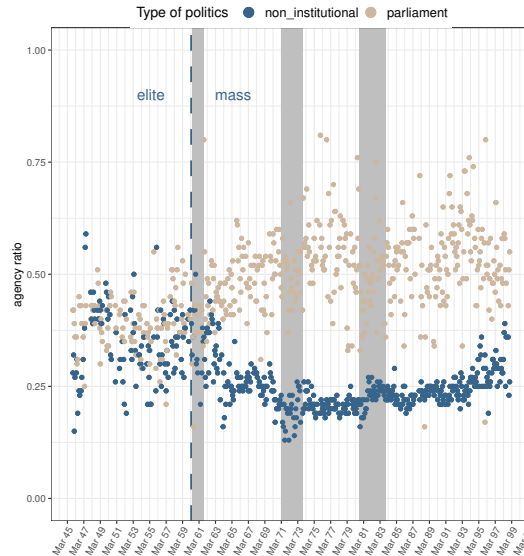
The analysis selects theoretically relevant values from these broader feature sets. **Mood** reveals a speaker’s perspective and here identifies verbs expressing potential or necessity. **Aspect** captures the duration of an action and whether it is habitual. Progressive aspect captures sustained action, while habitual aspect serves as an inverse indicator of non-routine action. All are measured as the percentage of verbs carrying the corresponding inflectional value.

Person information identifies whether agency is assigned to the speaker, the audience, or a third-person actor. The agency ratio then measures opponent-centeredness by dividing verbs with first- and second-person subjects by verbs with third-person subjects. Lower values indicate that more action is assigned to the opponent. Verb density does not tell us which specific dimension of this rhetorical strategy is at work. It captures the common action-oriented syntax behind action-language, while the five auxiliary indicators show how this strategy takes shape through different grammatical forms.

I assess convergent validity by examining whether these indicators covary with *verb (%)* in theoretically expected directions. The exercise does not require every dimension to move identically; rather, it asks whether they generally reinforce, rather than contradict, the action-oriented tendency captured by verb density. Potential, necessity, and progressive aspect should be positively correlated with verb density, whereas habitual aspect and the agency ratio should be negatively correlated with it.

Findings reported in [Appendix I.1](#) show that the correlations follow these expected directions, with an average absolute correlation coefficient of 0.5. Hypothesis testing with *t*-tests suggests that with the exception of habitual aspect all measures display a statistically significant difference between non-institutional and institutional politics ([Appendix I.2](#)). Compared with institutional politics, non-institutional actors use more verbs in areas that (1) denote potential and necessity and (2) represent sustained action, while assigning relatively more agency to the other side.

Figure 5: Agency of action in verbs



Notes: Gray shaded areas denote episodes of military control until the next general election. Data cover 518 months for the 1945-1998 period.

Figure 5 shows that the language of non-institutional politics is opponent-centric. For every verb with an in-group subject (I, we, or you¹⁸), socialist and ethnic outsiders use roughly four verbs with out-group subjects (they). This relationship is robust over four decades when movement support was mass-based. Another interesting pattern is the interaction between the languages of two groups.

¹⁸Since audiences of revolutionary periodicals are sympathetic groups who are expected to support or join action, “you” is considered part of the in-group.

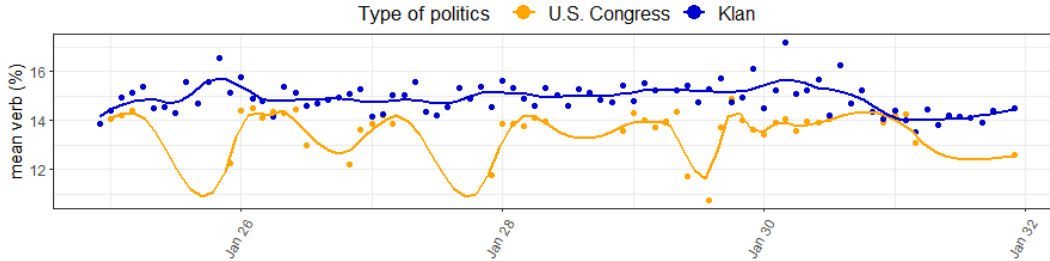
Agency ratios begin to move symmetrically, suggesting that their rhetoric becomes responsive to one another. A similar interaction can be observed for the measure *potential* (Appendix I.3): As verbs associated with *potential* rise in non-institutional politics, they decline among institutional actors.

Verbs denoting *necessity*¹⁹ are always in high demand in non-institutional politics. They underscore the role of determination and certainty in taking risky action. The emphasis on *necessity* also suggests that movement organizations balance their rhetoric about potential with moral claims. Finally, *visualizations* demonstrate that several components of action-language become prominent after non-institutional politics becomes mass-based. This finding supports a central claim of the paper, namely that action-language is tied to community resources. This shift might also explain why non-routine action cannot distinguish between two types of politics when support for movements is limited to elites. Hence, non-routine action verbs become frequent after new forms of action take place with mass support.

6.2.3 External validity with the Ku Klux Klan

This part assesses the external validity of the findings regarding action-language. The case-selection, corpus construction, and measurement strategy were introduced earlier. In a nutshell, the interwar U.S. comparison evaluates whether the Turkish findings generalize across language, ideology, institutional design, and historical period. It pairs a right-wing outsider—the second Ku Klux Klan—with the U.S. Congress before the Cold War. It also exploits the fact that the U.S. presidential system differs from parliamentary rule in Turkey and that English and Turkish differ syntactically. Using the U.S. corpora, the analysis compares monthly verb density in the Klan’s official publication, the *Kourier*, and the *Congressional Record*. Both corpora cover December 1924 through December 1931 and are aggregated at the month-year level. The comparison therefore tests whether the verb gap persists beyond the Turkish setting while retaining the division between non-institutional and institutional politics.

Figure 6: A comparison of all verb density between the U.S. Congress and the Ku Klux Klan



Notes: The monthly data cover December 1924–December 1931. The U.S. Congress corpus draws on proceedings from the Senate and House and represents institutional politics. The Ku Klux Klan represents non-institutional politics, and the evidence comes from its official publication, the *Kourier*.

The first finding is that, as an outsider, the Klan used more verbs than its institutional counterpart, the U.S. Congress (Figure 6).²⁰ While the mean value of monthly verb density for Congress ($n=45$) is 13.70 percent, this figure rises to 14.90 percent for the Klan ($n=84$). As such, the main pattern observed earlier on non-institutional politics holds across a different language, movement, and institutional setting. Two subtler patterns also coincide. First, a clear separation between the two groups emerges around a certain threshold. In the Klan case, the threshold is at 14 percent verb density. Second, verb density varies less for movement organizations, suggesting greater continuity in the Klan’s action-language intensity over time.

The visual separation is also supported by hypothesis testing. Replicating the Turkish design, a one-sided, two-sample *t*-test with unequal variances confirms that mean verb density is significantly higher

¹⁹Note that a verb expresses necessity with a suffix added to it in Turkish. Hence, verbs associated with necessity do not refer to a specific group of verbs. This syntactic property avoids sampling problems often associated with dictionary-based approaches.

²⁰All verbs include auxiliary verbs to ensure an apples-to-apples comparison with the Turkish case, where modality is expressed through verbal suffixes rather than separate auxiliaries.

in the Klan corpus. The lower bound of the 95% one-sided confidence interval is 1.02 percentage points. Separate tests of verbs and auxiliary verbs, as well as a two-sided test, produce the same substantive conclusion. The complete results are in [Table J1](#), Appendix J. In sum, findings from a setting that has a similar division of political space but otherwise exhibits key differences lend further support to the external validity of action-language across time and space.

7 Conclusion

This paper is built around a simple idea: the language actors use depends on their position in political space. Without access to institutional resources, outsiders have no choice but to rely on community resources, and to do so, they use action-language to convince community members to join action. Further analysis shows that power, and especially its latent type, increases action-language intensity among movement organizations. They ask for more commitment from the community only after they acquire latent power through legibility. Hence, getting familiar with the spaces where community members live and learning about the distribution of community resources serve as prerequisites for increased requests for community action.

Drawing on seven datasets and one million pages of text, this paper presented evidence from Turkey and the United States. It showed that action-language is a defining property of non-institutional politics irrespective of ideology, language, movement type, historical period, and institutional design. The construct validity discussion further demonstrated that movement organizations not only use more verbs but also verbs of different kinds. They emphasize sustained and non-routine action, frame action as both necessary and possible, and keep attention focused on opponents. Finally, movement-level evidence from 300 periodicals spanning more than half a century corroborated the positive effect of latent power on action-language intensity, supporting the claim that these findings are generalizable beyond a single movement organization.

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Appendices

A What we know about non-institutional politics

A.1 Language as the missing link

Decades of research have taught us a great deal about non-institutional politics. Focusing on its violent type, conflict scholarship revealed that both grievances and opportunities matter to start a rebellion. Translating these ideas into empirical work, high-profile research demonstrated that excluded groups (Cederman, Weidmann and Gleditsch, 2011) and spots with weak state presence (Fearon and Laitin, 2003) are more likely to rise up against government. Researchers then documented how opportunity and grievances work, showing that (1) economic costs of joining a rebellion are relatively low compared to not joining, and (2) group exclusion is sustained through weak representation and inefficient redistribution of state resources. All in all, conflict onset research provided a window into the causes of armed action that is large and long enough to hurt a government (Collier and Hoeffler, 2004). Yet, given its focus on extreme cases, this research agenda gave us few clues about the rest of armed actors' universe: the politics of countless violent challengers whose actions failed to reach that scale.

As interest shifted to conflict dynamics, researchers have found robust patterns inside civil wars (Kalyvas, 2006; Toft and Zhukov, 2015). The main question here has been causes, types and consequences of civilian targeting (Weinstein, 2006). While well-cited research highlighted limited territorial control, dependence on natural resources, and a strong opponent as determinants of indiscriminate targeting, others have shown that combatant's identity shapes perceptions of civilian victimization (Lyall, Blair and Imai, 2013). More recently, in-depth case studies turned the attention to insurgent governance (Arjona, 2016; Mampilly, 2012) with the premise that insurgents do more than deliver punishment on the ground. For instance, one explanation tied members' commitment to insurgency to its exclusive provisioning of local goods (Berman and Laitin, 2008) which also had a robust effect on conflict negotiations (Heger and Jung, 2017). As a whole, this collective effort led to a proliferation of disaggregated conflict data, fueling sub-national and regional studies (Buhaug et al., 2011). On the flip side, the availability of numerous datasets alleviated concerns about data (i.e. reporting bias) (Baum and Zhukov, 2015; Miller et al., 2022; Weidmann, 2016) and turned generality of findings into a harder goal to achieve.

The other path to study of non-institutional politics (in which political violence plays a peripheral role) is social movement studies (McAdam, Tarrow and Tilly, 2001). This literature demonstrated the effects of opportunity and threat dynamics on movement fortunes (McAdam, 1983; Meyer and Staggengborg, 1996), tactical learning across movements (Wang and Soule, 2012), and ways that a protest cycle ends (Almeida, 2003). Early efforts also highlighted resource-mobilization (McCarthy and Zald, 1977) and framing (Benford and Snow, 2000) as ways that activists solve collective action problems. More recent work put the emphasis on the agenda setting stage, demonstrating the effect of protest on institutional politics (Andrews, 2018; Wasow, 2020). Finally, a number of studies coming from European settings carved out an intellectual space for revolutionary groups that do not neatly fit into the social movement studies paradigm or models of insurgency (Della Porta, 2013).

The above literature review took the long-term view and focused on major debates and key findings in the scholarship. While this approach is selective in its focus on high-profile research, its major benefit is capturing broad trends.¹ In this respect, a major gap in both literatures has been language. Until recently, little was known about the language of these outsiders. This need becomes all the more urgent today as outsiders challenge and redesign institutional politics in fundamental ways. Recent advances in document digitization and automated text analysis offer an opportunity to address the issue (Grimmer and Stewart, 2013).

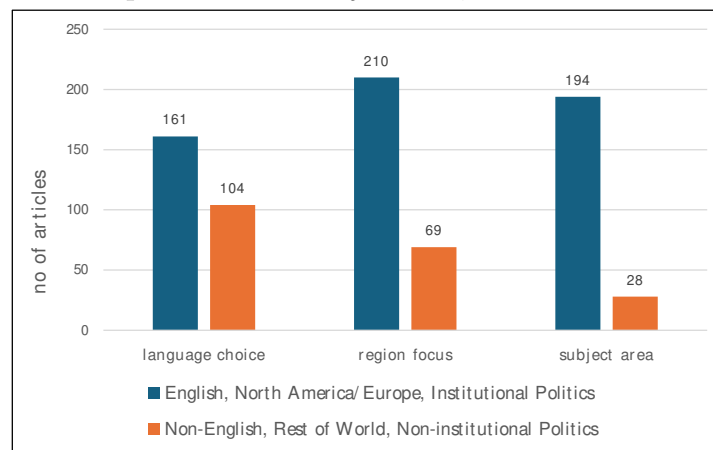
¹The alternative is state of the field approaches that take a ground-up view with an in-depth treatment of the field. While attentive to specific findings, methodologies, and research questions, this richer analysis is less suitable for our purpose here, which is identifying long-term trends that shaped the field in the last three decades.

A.2 Where’s non-institutional politics? A meta-analysis of text-as-data research

A meta-analysis of political science research that uses text as data can register the progress made in the last 25 years. In doing so, it can reveal if and how language has entered the study of non-institutional politics. For this purpose, I survey articles published in the top 20 political science journals in the 2000-2024 period and build a dataset with articles that employ text analysis. Journal rankings are based on [Journal Citation Reports \(2025\)](#), the time range is long enough to capture text analysis research early on, and the broad nature of rankings guarantees the representativeness of the dataset by including general audience, subfield, and area specific journals. Finally, an article entered the dataset if an automated search with the bigram “text analysis” returned a positive result after scanning the entire text, and the dataset took its final form with 343 articles.

The literature review that relies on articles from the same dataset demonstrates that institutional politics got most of the attention. Using text as data, researchers have found new ways to primarily position politicians and political parties on a policy scale and register the ups and downs of their emotive rhetoric in legislative bodies. The growing literature on political control seems to be the exception ([Hassan, Mattingly and Nugent, 2022](#); [Carter and Carter, 2023](#); [Pan and Siegel, 2020](#)). A classification of articles from the dataset quantifies this priority. As a rough estimate, for every article on non-institutional politics, there are roughly seven that deal with parliaments, political parties and politicians (Figure A1). Other columns in Figure A1 illustrate that this focus is mostly confined to North American and European settings and typically works with the use of corpora in English.

Figure A1: Articles using text analysis in top 20 political science journals, 2000-2024



Notes: Journals are ranked based on normalized eigenfactor scores in Journal Citation Reports (2025). This metric measures how influential a journal is compared to an average influence journal. I populate the dataset with articles (n=343) by running an automated search for the bigram “text analysis”. The third category for each variable is not shown for visualization purposes.

Meanwhile, methodological treatments that are also discussed at some length later had two main objectives: (1) improve techniques of text analysis that primarily fall under unsupervised learning approaches ([Rossiter, 2022](#)) and (2) unpack key parts of research to make them more efficient (coding) ([Benoit et al., 2016](#); [Mikhaylov, Laver and Benoit, 2012](#)), inference friendly (dimension reduction and validation) ([Quinn et al., 2010](#); [Lowe and Benoit, 2013](#); [Roberts, Stewart and Nielsen, 2020](#)), and researcher-conscious choices (pre-processing) ([Denny and Spirling, 2018](#)). Both objectives had the ultimate goal of discovering semantic relationships in the data.

As the meta-analysis and the accompanying literature review show, rapid growth of text as data research has failed to fill the language gap in conflict and social movement scholarships. Substantive treatments have focused on politicians, political parties and legislatures, leaving little room for the study of non-institutional politics. In methodological terms, most of the energy is spent on uncovering semantic relations using techniques such as topic modeling and word embeddings. Accordingly, syntax remained underutilized to discover an actor’s rhetoric, which works in tandem with motivations,

preferences, or capabilities. The patterns summarized here are examined in detail in the next section.

A.3 Text as data research detailed

A.3.1 Substantive treatments

The first robust pattern that emerges from the analysis is the fact that the bulk of research is about position-taking in institutional politics (Laver, 2014; Slapin and Proksch, 2008). Accordingly, there has been a flurry of articles on politicians, political parties, governments, and legislatures that utilize textual information to discover a latent trait (i.e. a politician’s position on immigration) (Dancygier and Margalit, 2020). Most of this effort went to explaining policy. Recent research has demonstrated that politicians take certain policy positions and adjust their language because of tactical incentives (Bräuninger, Müller and Stecker, 2016), public opinion (Hager and Hilbig, 2020), campaign contributions (Bonica, 2018), electoral framework (Catalinac, 2016) and size of constituency (Vishwanath, 2025).

Text analysis is also employed to understand how political parties behave. Current scholarship connects party rhetoric to voter mobilization (Jung, 2020), explores the consequences of intraparty competition (Baumann, Debus and Klingelhöfer, 2017; Ceron, 2015; Greene and Haber, 2016), and asks which areas separate parties from one another (Proksch and Slapin, 2010). Findings point to differences in levels of populism (Di Cocco and Monechi, 2022), cultural preferences (Diermeier et al., 2012) and nostalgia rhetoric (Müller and Proksch, 2024), all of which might explain the distinct character of (far) right parties (Cerrone, 2023). Meanwhile, other research approached political parties as dynamic and interactive entities, examining whether policy diffusion works (Düpont and Rachuj, 2022; Gilardi, Shipan and Wüest, 2021) or when they cooperate or antagonize each other (Herzog and Benoit, 2015; König and Finke, 2015; Merkley and Stecula, 2021).

Consistent with the above agenda, scholars who study legislative behavior turned to text to unpack the policy-making process. Rooted in the American politics subfield, this line of research discovered topics of legislative speeches in the Senate (Quinn et al., 2010), strategic timing behind executive orders (Djourelouva and Durante, 2022), deliberation by FOMC² on monetary policy (Schonhardt-Bailey, 2013), and why and how “hitch-hiker” bills work (Casas, Denny and Wilkerson, 2020). Shifting the attention to emotions, comparative work on legislatures has shown when sentimentality ticks up, which actors are more likely to use emotive rhetoric, and to what end (Osnabrügge, Hobolt and Rodon, 2021). Lastly, there is some discussion on legislative decorum (Goet, 2021) and experience. Focusing on women members, a number of studies demonstrated that while debating styles of women have changed over time (Hargrave and Blumenau, 2022), compared to men, women still show up less as floor speakers (Vallejo Vera and Gómez Vidal, 2022).

Most of the current research on governments has renewed interest in what states do to keep citizens in check (Pan and Siegel, 2020). Focusing on authoritarian settings (Rosenfeld and Wallace, 2024), Jennifer Pan and her co-authors have shown how the Chinese government shifts the agenda online (King, Pan and Roberts, 2017) and drops citizen complaints against officials in bureaucratic reporting (Pan and Chen, 2018). The latter finding is consistent with the broader censorship agenda as authoritarian governments ban content to punish dissent and reward supporters (Esberg, 2020). Another instrument in maintaining political order is propaganda (Carter and Carter, 2023). With the help of a large corpus compiled from state-run newspapers, Carter and Carter (2021, 2022) show that state propaganda reduces future protest and intensifies during pro-democracy anniversaries. Propaganda can also acquire positive content. Research coming from the Russian Federation reveals that government and its agents emphasize performance and extend praise for the autocrat depending on contextual factors (Baturu and Tolstrup, 2024; Baturu, Khokhlov and Tolstrup, 2025).

Text also formed the evidentiary basis for a number of studies on judiciary, bureaucracy and media. Extant research on judiciary has in particular explored Supreme Court opinions, looking at tone (Knox and Lucas, 2021), dissent (Rice, 2017), and lower court influence (Corley, Collins Jr and Calvin, 2011). Studies on bureaucracy have found that bureaucratic discretion comes with independence (Vannoni, Ash and Morelli, 2021), and during a crisis moment, the position that advisors have inside the bureaucracy determines the type of information they share with the leader without necessarily changing policy outcomes (Schub, 2022). Finally, a diverse group of studies has examined how media coverage of corruption is associated with press laws (Stanig, 2015) and whether (1) social media facilitates political

²FOMC refers to Federal Open Market Committee.

protest (Jost et al., 2018), (2) public support for peace on social media reduces conflict intensity (Zeit-zoff, 2018) and (3) Americans consume media via echo chambers (Guess, 2021).

A.3.2 Methodological treatments

As text represents a distinct data type, considerable energy is spent on finding ways to accurately classify text. The second robust pattern about political science research that uses text as data then is that most of the current applications are about semantics. Topic models, which generate latent themes from words used in a corpus, have by far attracted the most attention (Roberts et al., 2014; Lucas et al., 2015). This bag-of-words approach calculates probabilities for document-topic (topical prevalence) and topic-word (topical content) proportions.³ In doing so, it allows researchers to capture variation across actors, policies, and ideas by comparing documents (Bush and Clayton, 2023; Hanania, 2021; Kraft, 2024). Recently, Rossiter (2022) extended the discussion to interactive settings to identify topic shifts, and De Vries, Schoonvelde and Schumacher (2018) found that the texts generated by Google Translate produce reliable results for topic modeling.

Recently, other semantic approaches that also rely on unsupervised learning have come to the forefront. Most prominently, word embeddings approach is on the ascendancy (Rheault and Cochrane, 2020). Word embeddings are vector-based representations of words based on surrounding words and work to capture semantic similarity.⁴ In doing so, they reduce dimensionality and capture context better by dealing with the issue of polysemy. Rodriguez and Spirling (2022) recently put word embeddings in a regression framework and offered practical guidance about parameter tuning. Other work provided multi-lingual sentence embeddings (Licht, 2023), utilized word embeddings for long short-term memory models to capture time dependencies inside text (Chang and Masterson, 2020), and compared the performance of dictionary-based, word embedding and transformer models (Widmann and Wich, 2023).

Meanwhile, supervised learning in which the researcher labels data in the training set to predict labels in the test set is also gaining momentum in political science. Researchers have suggested ways to reduce costs associated with labeling (Miller, Linder and Mebane Jr, 2018), to do multi-label predictions (Erlich et al., 2022) and how to accomplish both goals (Sebők and Kacsuk, 2021). One practical recommendation here is to work with keywords rather than topics as labels for text classification (Barberá et al., 2021). Accordingly, a number of studies have already employed supervised learning as their main methodology. Using expert reports and newspapers, these papers tried to predict conflict onset (Mueller and Rauh, 2018), conflict intensity (Häffner et al., 2023) or when parties go from violence to non-violence (Shellman, Levey and Young, 2013).

Additionally, methodological treatments involved interventions to key aspects of text analysis research. One such area is coding. While consensus about gold standards has yet to emerge, researchers identified human coding problems (Mikhaylov, Laver and Benoit, 2012), made performance comparisons between human and machine coding (Cordell et al., 2020), and provided detailed guidance about best practices in crowd-sourced coding that can produce reliable and reproducible data without relying on domain experts (Benoit et al., 2016; Carlson and Montgomery, 2017). For instance, one recent contribution has demonstrated that automated coding of campaign advertisements is now a possibility (Tarr, Hwang and Imai, 2023). Moving to the pre-processing step, in an important paper, Denny and Spirling (2018) drew attention to the choices researchers make before tokenization, which has non-trivial consequences. Two other areas of active search have been dimension reduction (Roberts, Stewart and Nielsen, 2020; Simon and Xenos, 2004) and validating findings (Lowe and Benoit, 2013).

A.4 A way forward

This study addresses the gaps identified above by examining the language of non-institutional politics through syntax. Rather than treating text primarily as a source of topics, positions, or sentiment, it uses syntactic structure to identify how outsiders formulate political action. Computational linguistics (Jurafsky and Martin, 2023; Manning and Schutze, 1999) makes this possible by allowing researchers to recover grammatical relations across large corpora that would be infeasible to code by hand. In this sense, the paper uses machine learning to scale inference about language.

³Latent Dirichlet Allocation treats documents as distributions over topics, and topics as distributions over words.

⁴They do this via cosine similarity that is the angle between the two vectors based on distance and direction.

The study also joins a smaller body of work that approaches political language through grammatical categories. Small but vibrant research communities in social psychology ([Cichocka et al., 2016](#)), political communication ([Van Atteveldt et al., 2017](#)), and political science ([Jones, 2016](#); [Liu, 2022](#); [Widmann, 2021](#); [McMahon, 2018](#)) have successfully connected politics to linguistic forms. Much of this work remains focused on politicians, parties, or other actors inside institutional politics. By shifting attention to insurgencies, revolutionary groups, and social movement organizations, this paper extends syntactic analysis to actors located outside institutional boundaries.

Finally, the paper is in conversation with research on non-institutional politics that uses text as data. A large part of this effort went to explaining interactions between two types of politics. Accordingly, while a collection of papers ([Hassan, Mattingly and Nugent, 2022](#); [Pan and Siegel, 2020](#)) explores what states do to stifle non-institutional politics, other works discuss how non-institutional politics influences processes such as lobbying, voting and negotiations with rebels ([Dwidar, 2022](#); [Heger and Jung, 2017](#); [Wasow, 2020](#)). Meanwhile, rhetoric emerged as a major area that is devoted to the study of non-institutional politics. In one such paper, [Karell and Freedman \(2019\)](#) argue that radical rhetoric is shaped by twin discourses of external enemies and internal transformation. Similar studies show that the language of activists becomes more extreme with exile ([Esberg and Siegel, 2023](#)) and violence ([Freedman, 2019](#); [Mitts, 2019](#)) and the need to recruit new members empowers online female preachers in an otherwise patriarchal movement ([Nielsen, 2020](#)). By treating political language as the dependent variable, this paper belongs to the last group of studies. Its contribution is to show that the syntax of action-language separates all non-institutional politics from its institutional counterpart and its intensity varies with power.

B A cheat sheet on theory

B.1 Glossary of key concepts and terms

This paper revolves around fourteen key items: ten concepts and four terms. Each item is designated with boldface and given a short description that either comes from the main text or offers a compatible definition. Concepts and terms are treated separately and organized in alphabetical order.

Concepts

Action-language A rhetorical style in non-institutional politics that turns political claims into calls for community action. It characterizes the language of the alternative knowledge field and works through syntax and semantics. Its purpose is to convince community members to take action. Representing a movement organization's requests for community action, it manages expectations.

Community organizing A movement organization's effort to build reach inside the community. It starts with identifying a target audience, grows through legibility and contact, and culminates with tacit knowledge. It produces latent power.

Community resources Tangible and intangible goods that actors need in order to materialize any form of collective action. They range from time to human labor but also include emotional goods such as sacrifice. They are distributed unevenly across time and space.

Institutional politics The practice of making community-level decisions based on formal or informal rules of representation. It works through designated actors, mechanisms, and venues that clearly define what politics is and how it ought to be practiced.

Latent power Produced by community organizing. It captures future potential by making community resources visible and available for later mobilization, without yet putting those resources into use.

Legibility Information about the community and its resources. It allows a movement organization to identify target audiences, locate supporters and opponents, and build group profiles in space. It is the first observable step in community organizing and a prerequisite for developing tacit knowledge.

Mobilization Successful utilization of community resources by a movement organization. It starts when community members perform movement roles and materializes in attacks, protests, and other repertoires that involve community members.

Non-institutional politics Any politics outside the boundaries of institutional politics. It includes insurgencies, revolutionary and reactionary groups, as well as social movements.

Power The ability of a movement organization to extend its reach inside the community and extract the necessary resources for an often risky venture.

Realized power Produced by mobilization. It captures community resources already put into use through attacks, protests, or other forms of collective action, and therefore reflects past performance.

Terms

Alternative knowledge field A communication space in non-institutional politics where social and political reality is given an alternative interpretation. It grows with new forms of communication and promotes a distinct language use in terms of syntax and semantics.

Movement A collection of actors, behaviors and ideas that challenge existing boundaries of institutional politics. It pursues a range of outcomes from a total overhaul of the system to changing terms of inclusion.

Movement organization An actor that promotes movement goals irrespective of its means or repertoires. It includes all political outsiders, from insurgent groups to social movement organizations.

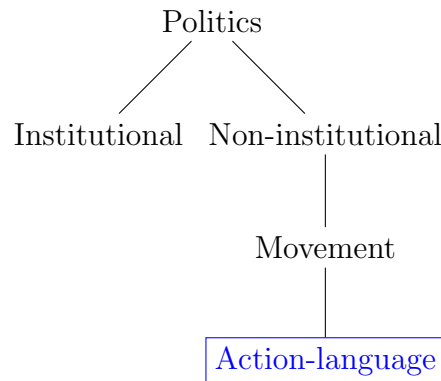
Outsider Any actor that remains excluded from an institutional setting. Movement organizations are a subset of outsiders.

B.2 Concept mapping

This subsection gives a visual representation of the theory using key concepts and terms discussed above. It has three parts. First, it positions action-language in political space. Second, it shows how power explains variation in action-language intensity. Third, it identifies the two channels through which power shapes rhetoric: community organizing and mobilization. The tripartite theoretical model is also consistent with the empirical strategy employed in the paper in terms of research design, estimation strategy, and the discussion of main findings.

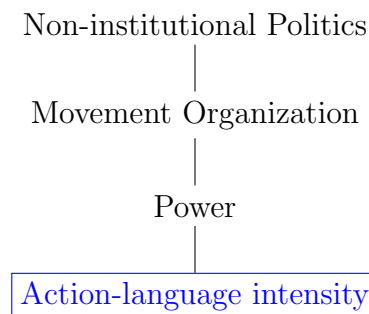
B.2.1 Action-language

Figure B1: Positioning action-language in political space



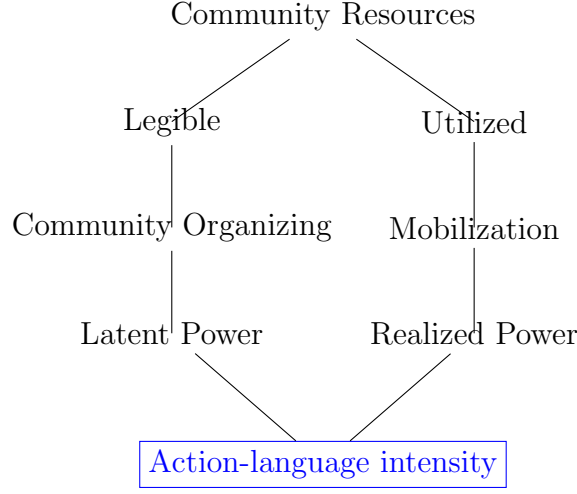
B.2.2 Power and action-language intensity

Figure B2: Power and action-language use



B.2.3 Community organizing and mobilization as channels of power

Figure B3: Community resources and power types



B.3 Latent power, realized power, and community resources

A simple inequality clarifies the relationship between latent and realized power. Suppose that community resources have a range between 0 and 1, with 1 representing all resources embodied in the community. Further suppose that d denotes the amount of community resources that are already utilized by the movement organization, and f is the amount of community resources legible to the movement organization.

$$0 < d \leq f \leq 1 \quad (1)$$

Since a movement organization's survival depends on the community, d has to be above 0 by default. In other words, however small, some collective action such as an informal gathering (online or in person) must have occurred. In a world where all movement organizations only exist on paper, there can be no movement and hence no movement organization. Meanwhile, d will almost always be smaller than f although it is not theoretically impossible for it to be equal to f . The reason is that movement organizations are aware of and interested in more community resources than they already mobilized. Realized power refers to the resources already put into use; latent power refers to the broader set of legible resources that may be mobilized in the future.

It is also important to note that f is not the full stock of resources available in the community. It is only the fraction of community resources that are known by the movement organization. Accordingly, an outsider that has extended its reach throughout society might have an f value close to 1. At that point, a movement organization is aware of the distribution of community resources based on its efforts towards legibility, which brought group ties and identities into its purview. If those resources are then mobilized for organization-specific tasks, d and f move closer together. Finally, mobilizing these resources for organization-specific tasks would mean that the values of d and f would not only be almost equal but also very close to 1, an episode that can be characterized as a revolutionary situation.

C Action-language: t-tests

C.1 Alternative specifications

Table C1: Comparing verb density in non-institutional and institutional politics

t-test specification	<i>t</i>	<i>df</i>	<i>p-value</i>	95% CI
one-sided, var unequal	29.63	668	< 0.001***	[2.33, Inf]
two-sided	29.63	668	< 0.001***	[2.30, 2.63]
var equal	30.35	866	< 0.001***	[2.33, Inf]
paired	25.40	404	< 0.001***	[2.31, Inf]
token size > 10k	30.37	636.35	< 0.001***	[2.36, Inf]
token range, middle 50%	25.87	321.27	< 0.001***	[2.50, Inf]

Notes. The monthly data cover June 1960- November 1998 period. Socialist and ethnic corpora come from revolutionary periodicals and together represent non-institutional politics. Meetings of the Turkish parliament stand for institutional politics. Means in [section 6.1.1](#) are computed over all available months for each corpus; the two-sample tests use months with observations in both. *T* stands for t-statistic, *df* for degrees of freedom, and 95% CI for a 95 % confidence interval. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

C.2 Scope conditions

Table C2: Comparing relative verb use in subgroups

subgroup features	episode	<i>t</i>	<i>df</i>	<i>p-value</i>	95% CI
elite support, socialist mov't	Nov. 1945 - Apr. 1960	4.92	266.33	< 0.001***	[0.41, 0.96]
elite support, ethnic mov't	Mar. 1975 - Aug. 1980	4.18	58.06	< 0.001***	[0.90, 2.57]
elite support, ethnic mov't, mil. rule	Oct. 1980 - Oct. 1983	-0.70	55.38	0.48	[-0.77, 0.37]
elite support, socialist mov't, mil. rule	June 1960 - Nov. 1961; Oct. 1980 - Oct. 1983	2.47	98.73	0.015*	[0.10, 0.96]

Notes. Two-tailed t-tests with unequal variances. Socialist and ethnic corpora come from revolutionary periodicals and together represent non-institutional politics. Meetings of the Turkish parliament stand for institutional politics. Subgroup features are support size (elite or mass), movement identity (socialist or ethnic), and regime type (democracy or military rule). Episode under military rule refers to the time between a military coup and the next multi-party elections. *T* stands for t-statistic, *df* for degrees of freedom, and 95% CI for a 95 % confidence interval. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

D Power: synthetic control method

D.1 Donor pool

Table D1: Donor pool from which synthetic control units are chosen

organization name	movement
Socialist Party of Turkish Kurdistan (TKSP-PSK)	ethnic
Small Kurdish groups (Kawa, KUK, KUK-SE, TKDP, Rızgari, Ala Rızgari, PPKK)	ethnic
Communist Party of Turkey (TKP)	socialist
Communist Party of Turkey/Marxist-Leninist (TKP/ML TIKKO)	socialist
Revolutionary Path (Dev-Yol)	socialist
Socialist Workers' Party of Turkey (TSIP)	socialist

D.2 Pretreatment covariates

Action-language use of movement organizations can be affected by opportunity and threat dynamics, movement type as well as their previous record. Table D2 presents a list of such variables informed by historical context.

Table D2: Pretreatment variables and their definitions

variable group & name	definition
<i>dependent variable lagged:</i>	
verb share (1984)	<i>verb</i> % of an org in the first 4-month interval of 1984
verb share (1983)	<i>verb</i> % of an org in the first 4-month interval of 1983
verb share (1982)	<i>verb</i> % of an org in the first 4-month interval of 1982
<i>opportunity:</i>	
domestic resistance	takes the value of 1 if the org resisted repression inside Turkey via armed action
regional access	takes the value of 1 if the org had one or more of the following outside Turkey but within the Middle East: presence, meetings or training camps
<i>threat:</i>	
state perceptions	total number of org mentions in daily Cumhuriyet. Mentions are on court cases brought against an org
<i>subgroup variation:</i>	
audience	takes the value of 1 if the intended audience is ethnic movement supporters and 0 for an exclusively socialist audience

Notes. Org is short for a movement organization and represents the level at which variables are defined. Unless specified, all variables are measured at 4-month intervals.

D.3 Average treatment effect on the treated

Table D3: Average treatment effect on the treated under different intervals

	4-month		6-month		2-month	
	pre-treat	post-treat	pre-treat	post-treat	pre-treat	post-treat
pkk	13.88	15.37	13.74	15.36	13.86	15.41
synthetic pkk	13.80	13.58	13.58	13.64	13.81	13.90
att		1.78		1.71		1.50
time units (n)	5	15	5	11	8	21

Notes. Time units (n) represent the number of intervals. Pre-treat and post-treat refer to pre-treatment and post-treatment periods. All values are in percentages.

D.4 Balance table, weights and placebo tests

Table D4: Balance table

Variable	PKK	synthetic PKK	donor sample
verb share (1984)	14.6	14.2	13.9
verb share (1983)	13.7	13.8	13.5
verb share (1982)	13.5	13.6	13.1
domestic resistance	1	0.54	0.35
regional access	1	0.44	0.14
state perceptions	12.4	19.7	15.4
audience	1	0.53	0.35

Notes. Please refer to Table D2 for variable definitions.

Figure D1: Weights of control units and covariates

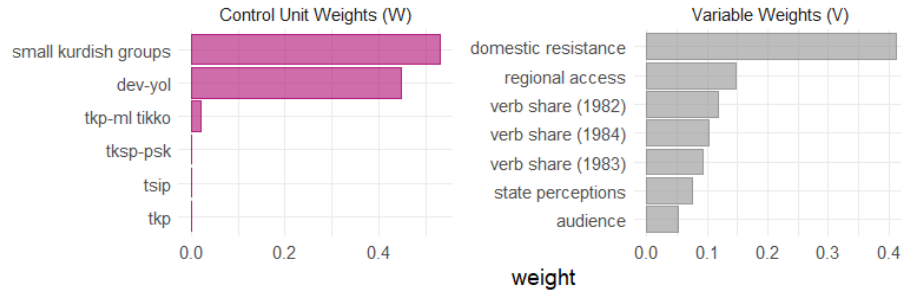
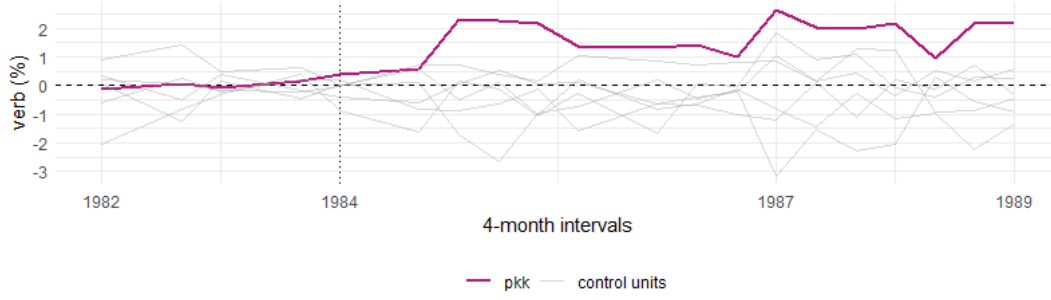


Figure D2: Change in verb use for other organizations after treatment



Notes: Figure D2 uses data from Figure 3. Dashed vertical line denotes the launching date of the guerrilla warfare by the PKK, which allowed the insurgent group to acquire power.

D.5 Weights in alternative specifications

Table D5: Weights in 2, 4 and 6-month intervals

Interval	control unit weights (%)	variable weights (%)
2-month	68.6	42.5
4-month	98.1	53
6-month	81.7	58.8

Notes. Control units are *dev-yol* and *small Kurdish groups*. Variables are *domestic resistance* and *verb share (1982)*.

D.6 Mean squared predictive error (MSPE) ratios

Table D6: MSPE ratios

Unit	treatment status	pre_mspe	post_mspe	mspe_ratio
pkk	treated	0.04	3.54	82.5
small kurdish groups	donor	0.36	0.97	2.71
dev-yol	donor	0.69	2.33	3.37
tkp-ml tikko	donor	1.17	0.83	0.70
tksp-psk	donor	0.10	0.64	6.16
tkp	donor	0.14	0.48	3.42
tsip	donor	0.02	0.39	15.6

Notes. MSPE ratio is calculated by dividing post-mspe by pre-mspe.

D.7 How extreme is the treated unit's MSPE ratio?

Table D7: MSPE ratios compared

	ratio of two highest MSPE ratios
Abadie, Diamond and Hainmueller (2010)	2.62
4-month interval	5.28
6-month interval	5.19
2-month interval	5.92

Notes. The highest MSPE ratio belongs to the treated unit and the second highest MSPE ratio belongs to a donor. Values for [Abadie, Diamond and Hainmueller \(2010\)](#) are taken from the tidysynth R package.

E Latent power: Instrumental variables analysis

E.1 Variables

E.1.1 Construction

I followed a number of steps in creating the variables. These steps account for three features of the data: (1) the number of administrative units changed over time, (2) mentions of administrative unit names can appear in more than one way, and (3) unit names have to be assigned to a specific administrative level, such as province (adm1) or district (adm2). All work is completed with the `quanteda` package in R.

First, I create a separate dictionary for each year. These dictionaries include the names of all administrative units available for that year.

Second, I identify 16 additional ways that each administrative unit name can appear in text and add them to every dictionary. This accounts for the fact that place names can appear in Turkish with suffixes, such as Istanbul’dan (from Istanbul).

Third, I calculate frequency and rank information for administrative units appearing in each month-year. The task is completed by counting the number of times that each administrative unit available in the dictionary from the previous year appears in the document.

Fourth, I create covariates. Separate columns show whether the administrative unit is a district or province and whether it is a major city. Other covariates calculate the total number of administrative mentions and total pages.

Finally, I construct variables using the data from the last two steps.

E.1.2 Description

All variables used in the latent-power models are presented below, followed by a brief definition. Variables other than the dependent variable and the main independent variable capture alternative ways that administrative mentions could affect verb density, serving as alternative explanations or controls.

Table E1: Latent power model variables and their definitions

variable name	definition
verb density (%)	share of verbs in PKK periodicals. Calculated as a percent.
district share (%)	number of unique district mentions divided by the sum of unique district and unique province mentions. Calculated as a percent.
district coverage (%)	number of unique district mentions divided by the total number of districts available the previous year.
major-city share (%)	share of administrative mentions coming from Istanbul, Ankara or Izmir. Calculated as a percent.
top-three concentration (%)	share of top three ranked units within all administrative mentions. Calculated as a percent.
administrative mentions per page	total number of administrative mentions divided by the number of pages
document volume (logged)	the natural logarithm of total number of pages

Notes. Unless specified, all variables are measured at one-month intervals, covering the 1982-1998 period based on text from PKK periodicals. Mentions are counted based on the availability of an administrative unit’s name in the previous year’s dictionary.

E.1.3 Summary statistics

Table E2: Descriptive statistics for latent-power models

Variable	min	median	mean	max	sd
verb density (%)	12.13	15.40	15.32	16.85	0.86
district share (%)	11.11	65.75	63.44	81.06	10.46
district coverage (%)	0.18	5.98	6.20	15.03	3.29
administrative expansion	0	0	0.47	1	0.50
major-city share (%)	0	9.40	9.84	26.47	4.45
top-three concentration (%)	8.63	21.49	24.92	100	11.51
administrative mentions per page	0.61	7.68	10.31	43.25	7.74
document volume (logged)	0	3.87	3.74	5.26	0.58

Notes. January 1982 - November 1998 period. $N = 202$. There is no data for September 1983.

E.2 Administrative expansion instrument

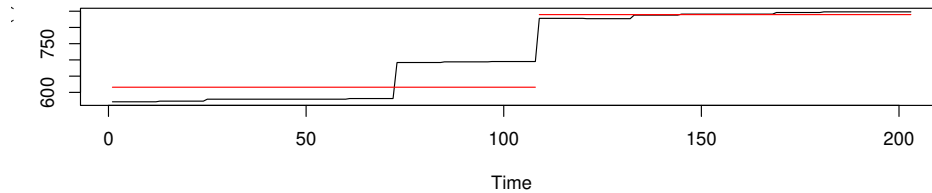
E.2.1 Construction

Administrative expansion instrument is created in two steps. Step one involved recording the number of districts (adm2) and provinces (adm1) in Turkey in a spreadsheet for each year (1981-1997). Step two required figuring out when administrative expansion occurred. For this purpose, I turned to change point detection algorithms. These algorithms can identify when a sudden shift occurs in historical (offline) or current (online) time-series data. Change point(s) can be found with reference to mean value or some other key statistic.

The paper employs the more precise and efficient PELT (Pruned Exact Linear Time) algorithm to identify a single change point in the data.¹ This point captures a major shift in the mean or cumulative sum value after the number of districts increased sharply in that year. Consistent with this expectation, I run the code separately for each statistic to see whether the analysis returns the same year for the shift to have occurred.

Analyses agree that a major shift took place in 1990 when the number of districts increased from 695 to 828. In Figure E1, this change point is reflected in a vertical line connecting month 108 and month 109. These months respectively correspond to December 1989 and January 1990 in the district data. While there was another spike in 1987, the algorithm chose 1990 over 1987 since I specified a single change point. Both spikes as moments of administrative expansion are consistent with substantive reading of the Turkish case and are simply observable from the plot. Accordingly, the *administrative expansion* instrument takes the value of 1 beginning in 1990 and 0 before that.

Figure E1: Change point in district size



Notes: y-axis represents the number of districts, and x-axis counts the number of months in the data chronologically.

¹The algorithm is available in the R package changepoint.

E.3 Full results

Table E3: First stage regression: administrative expansion and district share (%)

<i>Dependent variable: district share (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	SE	t value	p-value	95 % C.I.
administrative expansion	5.78	0.89	6.47	<0.001***	(4.01 , 7.54)
district coverage (%)	2.44	0.36	6.87	<0.001***	(1.74 , 3.14)
major-city share (%)	-0.38	0.10	-3.68	<0.001***	(-0.58 , -0.18)
top-three concentration (%)	0.01	0.05	0.10	0.92	(-0.09 , 0.10)
administrative mentions per page	-0.52	0.13	-3.92	<0.001***	(-0.78 , -0.26)
document volume (logged)	5.98	1.28	4.68	<0.001***	(3.46 , 8.49)
intercept	32.77	4.77	6.87	< 0.001***	(23.36 , 42.18)

Notes. Results from an OLS regression. District share (%) is the percent of unique administrative unit mentions coming from districts (adm2). Administrative expansion is the instrument. The model includes binary season fixed effects. $N = 202$. Model fit: $F(7, 194) = 63.48$, $p < 0.001$, $Adj. R^2 = 0.69$. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Table E4: Second stage IV regression: the effect of district share (%) on verb density (%)

<i>Dependent variable: verb density (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	Robust SE	t value	$Pr(> t)$	95 % C.I.
district share (%)	0.13	0.03	5.22	<0.001***	(0.08 , 0.18)
district coverage (%)	-0.43	0.10	-4.38	<0.001***	(-0.62 , -0.24)
major-city share (%)	0.037	0.018	2.01	0.046*	(0.001 , 0.073)
top-three concentration (%)	-0.017	0.012	-1.46	0.146	(-0.041 , 0.006)
administrative mentions per page	0.08	0.03	2.84	0.005**	(0.03 , 0.14)
document volume (logged)	-0.23	0.39	-0.59	0.554	(-1.00 , 0.54)
intercept	9.53	1.19	7.99	<0.001***	(7.18 , 11.89)

Notes. Results from a 2SLS regression obtained with the ivreg function from the AER package in R. Verb density (%) is the percent of verbs used in PKK periodicals in the following month. District share (%) is the instrumented independent variable. The model includes binary season fixed effects and is reported with robust standard errors. $N = 202$. First-stage weak instrument diagnostic $F(1, 194) = 41.81$, $p < 0.001$. Diagnostic based on non-robust covariance. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

E.4 Exclusion restriction

E.4.1 Falsification test in zero-first-stage populations

Table E5: Association between off-path administrative expansion instrument and district share (%)

<i>Dependent variable: district share (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	SE	t value	p-value	95 % C.I.
off-path administrative expansion	-0.05	0.05	-0.89	0.38	(-0.15, 0.06)
district coverage (%)	2.62	0.39	6.71	< 0.001***	(1.85, 3.38)
major-city share (%)	-0.20	0.11	-1.82	0.07	(-0.42, 0.02)
top-three concentration (%)	-0.05	0.06	-0.83	0.41	(-0.16, 0.06)
administrative mentions per page	-0.64	0.14	-4.44	< 0.001***	(-0.92, -0.36)
document volume (logged)	6.55	1.44	4.56	< 0.001***	(3.72, 9.38)
intercept	33.05	5.45	6.06	< 0.001***	(22.30, 43.80)

Notes. Results from an OLS regression. District share (%) is the number of unique district mentions divided by the sum of unique district and unique province mentions in PKK periodicals. Off-path administrative expansion is a placebo instrument that counts the number of newly created districts in the previous year in 13 provinces where the Kurdish-speaking population is consistently reported to be below 2 percent in the 1965 census; later demographic estimates (Mutlu, 1996) and surveys point to the same classification. The model includes binary season fixed effects. $N = 202$. Model fit: $F(7, 194) = 47.62$, $p < 0.001$, $Adj. R^2 = 0.62$. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Table E6: Association between off-path administrative expansion instrument and verb density (%)

<i>Dependent variable: verb density (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	SE	t value	p-value	95 % C.I.
off-path administrative expansion	-0.01	0.01	-1.08	0.28	(-0.02, 0.01)
district coverage (%)	-0.08	0.05	-1.78	0.08	(-0.17, 0.01)
major-city share (%)	0.001	0.013	0.06	0.95	(-0.03, 0.03)
top-three concentration (%)	-0.023	0.007	-3.46	< 0.001***	(-0.04, -0.01)
administrative mentions per page	-0.02	0.02	-0.97	0.34	(-0.05, 0.02)
document volume (logged)	0.76	0.17	4.42	< 0.001***	(0.42, 1.10)
intercept	13.69	0.65	21	< 0.001***	(12.40, 14.97)

Notes. Results from an OLS regression. Verb density (%) is the percentage of tokens tagged as verbs in PKK periodicals in each month-year. Off-path administrative expansion is a placebo instrument that counts the number of newly created districts in the previous year in 13 provinces where the Kurdish-speaking population is consistently reported to be below 2 percent in the 1965 census; later demographic estimates (Mutlu, 1996) and surveys point to the same classification. The model includes binary season fixed effects. $N = 202$. Model fit: $F(7, 194) = 8.43$, $p < 0.001$, $Adj. R^2 = 0.21$. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Taken together, the results support the zero-first-stage expectation. Off-path administrative expansion does not increase district share, indicating that district creation in these provinces does not generate added legibility for the PKK. It also does not predict verb density. This pattern provides no evidence that administrative expansion affects action-language through district creation as such; the instrument matters only where new districts can plausibly increase the movement organization's legibility of the community.

E.4.2 Negative-control outcome test

Table E7: Association between administrative expansion instrument and determiner share (%)

<i>Dependent variable: determiner share (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	SE	t value	p-value	95 % C.I.
administrative expansion	-0.019	0.031	-0.62	0.534	(-0.080, 0.042)
district coverage (%)	-0.002	0.012	-0.19	0.849	(-0.027, 0.022)
major-city share (%)	-0.003	0.004	-0.71	0.478	(-0.010, 0.005)
top-three concentration (%)	0.002	0.002	1.32	0.187	(-0.001, 0.006)
administrative mentions per page	-0.017	0.005	-3.70	< 0.001***	(-0.026, -0.008)
document volume (logged)	0.154	0.044	3.47	< 0.001***	(0.066, 0.241)
intercept	1.990	0.166	12.01	< 0.001***	(1.663, 2.317)

Notes. Results from an OLS regression. Determiner share (%) is the percentage of tokens tagged as determiners in PKK periodicals in each month-year. Administrative expansion is the instrument. The model includes binary season fixed effects. $N = 202$. Model fit: $F(7, 194) = 6.27$, $p < 0.001$, $Adj. R^2 = 0.16$. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

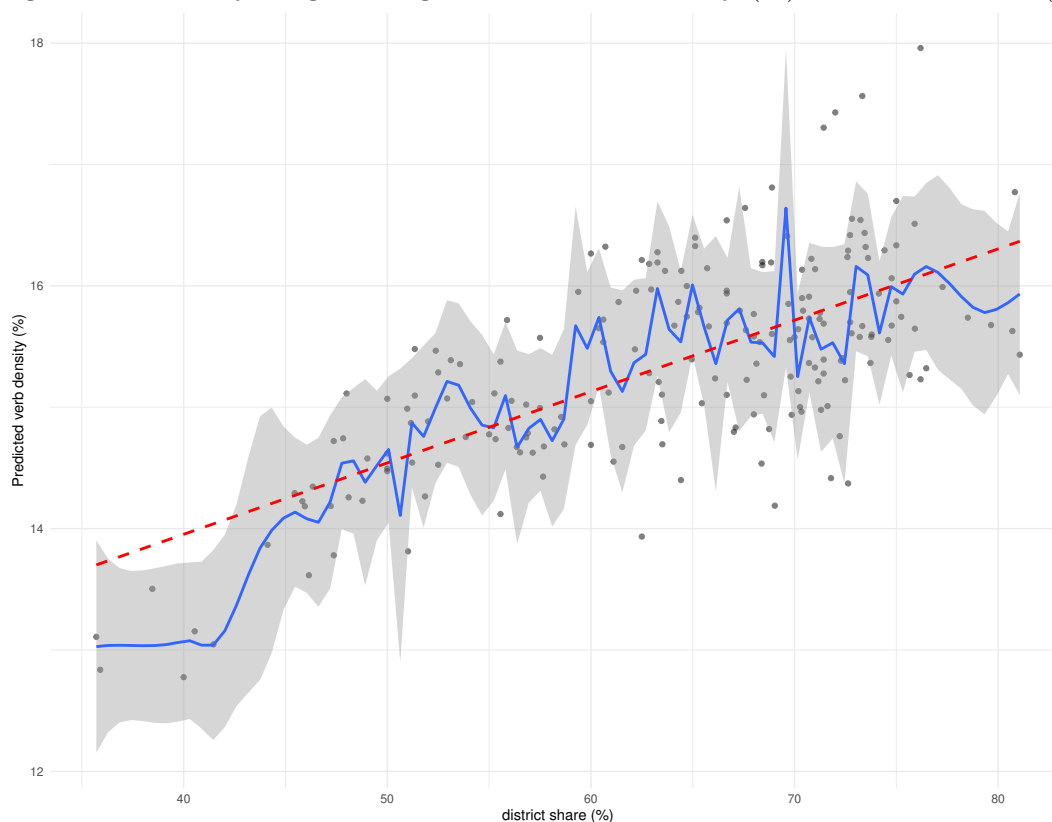
E.4.3 Horizontal administrative reach

As a targeted alternative-mediator check, I examine whether administrative expansion is associated with district coverage, defined as the percentage of available districts that appear in PKK periodicals in each month-year. District coverage is balanced across the two levels of the instrument: observations with administrative expansion have a mean district coverage of 6.13 percent, compared to 6.27 percent among observations without administrative expansion. The adjusted difference is -0.14 percentage points, the standardized difference is -0.04, and the z-statistic is -0.30. I also re-estimate the latent-power IV model without district coverage. Administrative expansion continues to predict district share in the first stage, and instrumented district share remains positively associated with verb density in the second stage. These results provide little evidence that the main relationship is driven by horizontal administrative reach.

E.5 Local regression

Analysis using local regression sheds light on the model's predictions on converting organizational legibility into pleas for action. Three intervals emerge in the data: Initial gains in legibility produce the largest increase in predicted verb density. The trend then slows down as legibility continues to grow, and deep legibility adds little to calls for action. Hence, the marginal effect of latent power on action-language use gets smaller over time. Diminishing returns on legibility are an expected outcome: as a movement organization extends its reach into the community, its ties with the community and realized power grow. Accordingly, the rate of additional requests goes down since (1) place-based legibility gives way to personal information and tacit knowledge through contact and (2) more action on behalf of the organization has already been completed.

Figure E2: Locally weighted regression of verb density (%) on district share (%)



Notes: *Predicted verb density (%)* represents the predicted values of the dependent variable. It is computed from the second stage of the IV analysis. *District share (%)* is the independent variable. Fifty percent district share corresponds to equal district and province mentions. Figure E2 uses local regression that takes five percent of the observations as the size of local neighborhood in every local fit. Blue line is the local fit line and red line is the global linear regression line. The gray area represents the 95 % confidence interval. Data points are the predicted values. The plot is made in ggplot with loess as the chosen method. One month with district share below 15 percent falls outside the plotted range.

Empirically, the three distinct episodes are visible in a LOESS plot in Figure E2. At low levels of district share, growing clarity in the PKK's ability to locate the community at a finer administrative scale translates into an increase of about one percentage point in predicted verb density. This episode of big jumps ends when district mentions catch up with province mentions, which puts the district share (%) variable at 50 percent. After that point, predicted verb density continues to rise, but at a slower rate. Finally, with the ratio of district to province mentions approaching 2—equivalent to a district share of 66 percent—additional gains from relative district mentions do not materialize. In other words, when greater legibility becomes widespread, it fails to incite fresh calls for community action.

F Latent power at the movement level: instrumental variables analysis

F.1 Instrumental variables analysis results

Table F1: First stage regression: the relationship between administrative expansion and district share (%)

<i>Dependent variable: district share (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	SE	t value	p-value	95 % C.I.
administrative expansion	5.27	1.47	3.58	< 0.001***	(2.38 , 8.16)
district coverage (%)	0.45	0.08	5.63	< 0.001***	(0.29 , 0.61)
major-city share (%)	0.04	0.05	0.77	0.442	(-0.06 , 0.13)
top-three concentration (%)	-0.24	0.05	-4.79	< 0.001***	(-0.34 , -0.14)
administrative mentions per page	0.63	0.39	1.63	0.104	(-0.13 , 1.39)
document volume (logged)	0.20	0.92	0.21	0.832	(-1.62 , 2.01)
intercept	62.50	6.07	10.29	< 0.001***	(50.57 , 74.43)

Notes. Results from an OLS regression. District share (%) is the percent of unique administrative unit mentions coming from districts (adm2). Administrative expansion is the instrument. The model includes binary season fixed effects. $N = 574$. Model fit: $F(7, 566) = 72.22$, $p < 0.001$, $Adj. R^2 = 0.47$. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

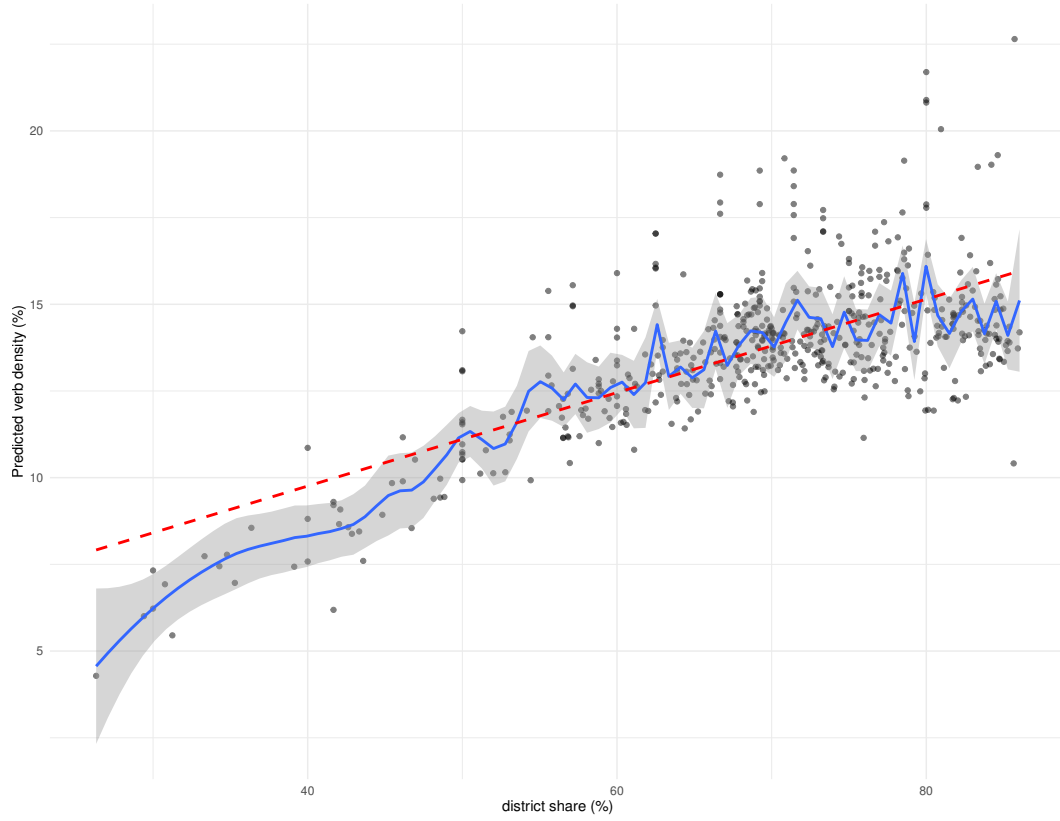
Table F2: Second stage IV regression: the effect of district share (%) on verb density (%)

<i>Dependent variable: verb density (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	Robust SE	t value	p-value	95 % C.I.
district share (%)	0.25	0.04	5.89	< 0.001***	(0.17 , 0.33)
district coverage (%)	-0.13	0.03	-3.99	< 0.001***	(-0.20 , -0.07)
major-city share (%)	-0.025	0.015	-1.72	0.086	(-0.053 , 0.004)
top-three concentration (%)	0.059	0.026	2.22	0.026*	(0.007 , 0.110)
administrative mentions per page	-0.15	0.10	-1.43	0.153	(-0.36 , 0.06)
document volume (logged)	0.22	0.31	0.71	0.478	(-0.39 , 0.83)
intercept	-2.73	4.40	-0.62	0.534	(-11.37 , 5.91)

Notes. Results from a 2SLS regression obtained with the ivreg function from the AER package in R. Verb density (%) is the percent of verbs used in revolutionary periodicals in the following month. District share (%) is the instrumented independent variable. The model includes season fixed effects and is reported with robust standard errors. $N = 574$. First-stage weak instrument diagnostic $F(1, 566) = 12.83$, $p < 0.001$. Diagnostic based on non-robust covariance. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

F.2 Local regression

Figure F1: Locally weighted regression of verb density (%) on district share (%)



Notes. *Predicted verb density (%)* represents the predicted values of the dependent variable, computed from the second stage of the IV analysis. *District share (%)* is the independent variable. Fifty percent district share corresponds to equal district and province mentions. Figure F1 uses local regression, with each local fit based on five percent of the observations. The blue line is the local fit, and the red line is the global linear-regression line. The gray area represents the 95% confidence interval. Data points are predicted values. The plot is made in ggplot using LOESS.

G Realized power: instrumental variables analysis

G.1 Variables

G.1.1 Description

All variables used in the realized-power models are presented below. The controls account for a potential alternative driver of action-language: domestic and international attention to the insurgent group and the Kurdish Question. The analysis also includes year fixed effects and seasonal fixed effects, which capture temporal changes in the insurgency’s attack cycle.

Table G1: Realized power model variables and their definitions

variable name	definition
verb density (%)	verb share in PKK periodicals. Calculated as a percent.
insurgent attacks	Number of insurgent attacks with at least one casualty among insurgent, government or civilian sides. Calculated as a count.
minutes	Mentions of the Kurdish Question in the minutes of the European Parliament. Calculated as a count.
Cumhuriyet	Mentions of the Kurdish Question in the left-leaning daily Cumhuriyet. Calculated as a count.
Le Monde	Mentions of the PKK insurgency in the left-leaning daily Le Monde. Calculated as a count.
temperature deviation	Instrument for attacks. Indicator variable equal to 1 when observed temperature is above its long-term average for the same month and 0 otherwise.
seasonal	Divides the year into high season, July to October; low season, March to June; and off season, November to February, based on the insurgency’s attack cycle. Categorical.

Notes. Unless specified, all variables are measured at one-month intervals and cover August 1984–November 1998.

G.1.2 Summary statistics

Table G2: Descriptive statistics for realized-power models

Variable	min	median	mean	max	sd
verb density (%)	14.20	15.49	15.58	16.85	0.53
insurgent attacks	0	11	19.99	199	28.29
minutes	0	0	0.57	4	0.94
Cumhuriyet	0	6	7.60	29	6.95
Le Monde	0	3	4.10	27	5.18
temperature deviation	0	1	0.53	1	0.50

Notes. August 1984–November 1998. $N = 172$.

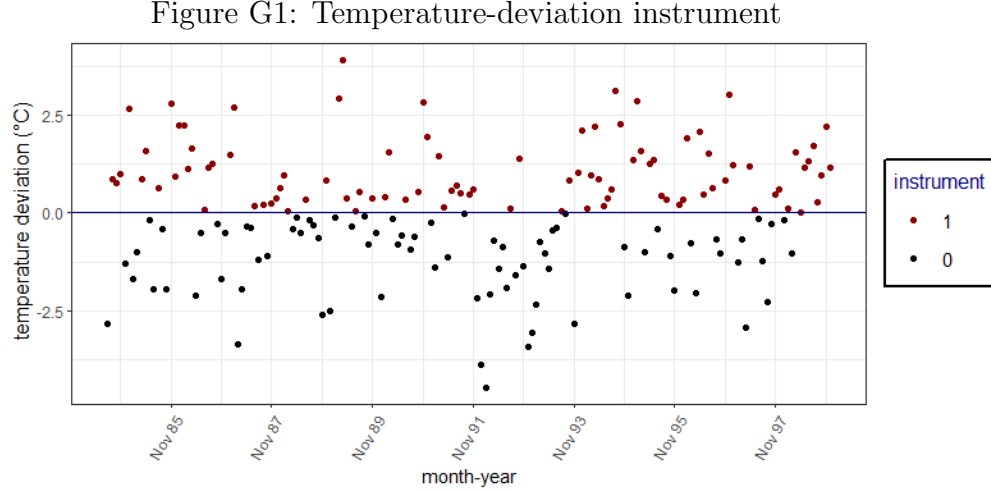
G.2 Temperature-deviation instrument

This subsection describes the construction of the temperature-deviation instrument used in the realized-power analysis. The goal is to capture hotter-than-usual conditions in areas where insurgent activity was possible, while separating unusual temperature from recurring seasonal patterns.

I begin by creating a district-month panel for Turkey during the analysis period. I then calculate the distance between each district and each weather station using district and station coordinates. Monthly temperature data from weather stations are converted into station-specific deviations by subtracting the long-term average for the same station-month from the observed monthly temperature. These deviations are then interpolated to the district level using inverse-distance weighting, which gives greater weight to nearby stations. Finally, I aggregate district-level temperature deviations to the

month-year level by averaging across districts. This produces a monthly measure of hotter-than-usual conditions that is constructed independently of the realized attack count.

The resulting instrument equals 1 when the monthly temperature deviation is above zero and 0 otherwise (Figure G1). Because the measure is based on deviations from month-specific averages, it captures unusually hot conditions rather than ordinary seasonal variation. The realized-power IV analysis then uses temperature deviation as the instrument for PKK attacks and estimates whether instrumented attacks predict subsequent verb density.



Notes. The figure plots the binary temperature-deviation instrument. The instrument is constructed by first estimating district-level deviations from long-term monthly temperature averages and averaging those deviations across districts within each month-year. It is then assigned the value of 1 when the monthly average is above zero and 0 otherwise. Data cover August 1984–November 1998.

G.3 First and second stage results

Table G3: First stage regression: the relationship between temperature deviation instrument and insurgent attacks

<i>Dependent variable: insurgent attacks</i>					
variable	Estimate	SE	z score	p-value	95 % C.I.
temperature deviation (instrument)	0.087	0.041	2.11	0.036*	(0.01, 0.17)
minutes	-0.073	0.020	-3.59	< 0.001***	(-0.11, -0.03)
Le Monde	0.039	0.004	9.72	< 0.001***	(0.03, 0.05)
Cumhuriyet	0.004	0.004	1.12	0.264	(0.00, 0.01)
intercept	1.116	0.279	4.18	< 0.001***	(0.57, 1.67)

Notes. Results from a Poisson regression. Coefficients and confidence intervals are on the log scale. The dependent variable is the number of PKK attacks in each month-year for the August 1984 - November 1998 period. $N = 172$. The model includes year and season fixed effects. Pseudo- R^2 (McFadden)= 0.66. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Table G4: Second stage IV regression: the effect of insurgent attacks on verb density (%)

<i>Dependent variable: verb density (%)</i>					
variable	Estimate	Robust SE	t value	p-value	95 % C.I.
insurgent attacks	0.006	0.011	0.56	0.573	(-0.02, 0.03)
minutes	0.006	0.076	0.07	0.941	(-0.14, 0.15)
Le Monde	-0.002	0.018	-0.13	0.899	(-0.04, 0.03)
Cumhuriyet	0.001	0.009	0.13	0.898	(-0.02, 0.02)
intercept	15.161	0.238	63.61	< 0.001***	(14.69, 15.63)

Notes. Results from a 2SLS regression obtained with the `ivreg` function from the `AER` package in R. Verb density (%) is the percentage of tokens tagged as verbs in PKK periodicals in the following month. The insurgent-attack count is the instrumented independent variable. The model includes year and season fixed effects. Robust standard errors are reported. $N = 172$. First-stage weak-instrument diagnostic: $F(1, 151) = 4.51$, $p = 0.035$. Diagnostic based on non-robust covariance. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

H Action-language: measurement validity

H.1 Confusion matrices

Table H1: Full confusion matrices and classification performance

UDPIPE classification	Movement		Parliament	
	Human verb	Human non-verb	Human verb	Human non-verb
verb	281	48	232	62
non-verb	47	2,438	24	2,207
Total	328	2,486	256	2,269
Precision (%)	85.41		78.91	
Recall (%)	85.67		90.63	

Notes. Columns report the human-coded classification and rows report the UDPIPE classification. Precision is the share of UDPIPE-coded verbs that are human-coded verbs; recall is the share of human-coded verbs identified by UDPIPE. The movement validation sample contains 2,814 tokens and the parliamentary validation sample contains 2,525 tokens.

H.2 Temporal blocks

Table H2: Classification error by temporal block

Corpus	Temporal block	Tokens	Human-coded verbs	False positives, n (%)	False negatives, n (%)
Movement	Block 1	1,245	147	21 (1.91)	27 (18.37)
Movement	Block 2	1,569	181	27 (1.95)	20 (11.05)
Parliament	Block 1	1,066	121	27 (2.86)	10 (8.26)
Parliament	Block 2	1,459	135	35 (2.64)	14 (10.37)

Notes. Temporal blocks are defined in the main text and are separated by the 1980 military coup. False-positive percentages are calculated among human-coded non-verbs; false-negative percentages are calculated among human-coded verbs.

H.3 Uncertainty in validation estimates

Table H3: Sentence-clustered bootstrap intervals for validation estimates

	Movement	Parliament	Movement–Parliament difference
False-positive rate (%)	1.93 [1.35, 2.53]	2.73 [2.02, 3.47]	-0.80 [-1.75, 0.14]
False-negative rate (%)	14.33 [10.16, 18.87]	9.38 [6.07, 13.00]	4.95 [-0.65, 10.59]
Precision (%)	85.41 [80.50, 89.91]	78.91 [73.79, 83.76]	–
Recall (%)	85.67 [81.13, 89.84]	90.62 [87.00, 93.93]	–
Error-corrected verb density (%)	14.03 [13.15, 15.03]	9.53 [8.66, 10.42]	4.50 [3.26, 5.79]

Notes. Entries are point estimates followed by 95% percentile intervals in brackets. Intervals are based on 10,000 sentence-clustered bootstrap replications that resample sentences separately within each corpus–temporal-block stratum. Differences are expressed in percentage points. Corrected-density intervals incorporate uncertainty in validation error rates while treating the original corpus-level UDPIPE verb densities as fixed.

Table H4: Sentence-clustered bootstrap intervals for tagging-error differences by temporal block

Corpus	Error type	Post-1980 minus pre-1980 difference (pp)	95% interval
Movement	False-positive	0.03	[-1.17, 1.21]
Movement	False-negative	-7.32	[-16.42, 1.64]
Parliament	False-positive	-0.21	[-1.78, 1.27]
Parliament	False-negative	2.11	[-4.85, 9.82]

Notes. Negative values indicate lower error rates after 1980. Intervals are based on 10,000 sentence-clustered bootstrap replications conducted separately within each temporal block.

I Action-language: construct validity

I.1 Correlations between verb (%) and auxiliary indicators of action-language

Table I1: Pearson correlations

variable	potential (%)	necessity (%)	progressive aspect (%)	habitual aspect (%)	agency
verb density (%)	0.55	0.47	0.58	-0.41	-0.34

Notes. Variables are measured at the movement level using the non-institutional politics corpus. Each observation is recorded at the month-year level. The analysis covers 518 months between 1945 and 1998. These months are selected based on data availability for the Turkish Parliament, allowing a one-to-one comparison between non-institutional and institutional politics.

I.2 Hypothesis-testing

Table I2: t-tests with auxiliary indicators of action-language

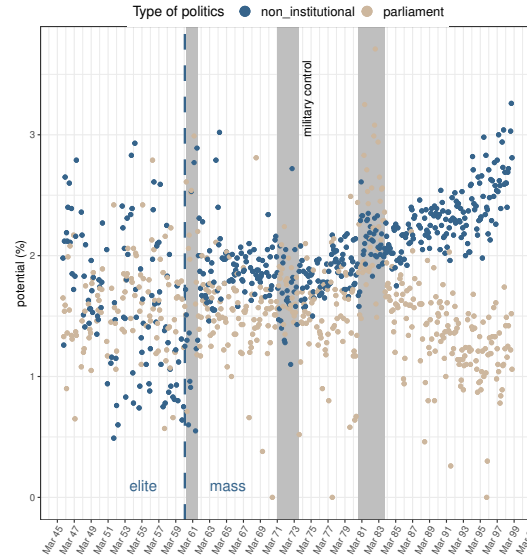
indicator	<i>t</i>	<i>df</i>	<i>p-value</i>	95% CI
potential (%)	14.66	1032.9	< 0.001***	(0.35, 0.46)
necessity (%)	26.94	943.06	< 0.001***	(0.27, 0.31)
progressive aspect (%)	8.62	1016	< 0.001***	(0.80, 1.27)
habitual aspect (%)	0.55	1008.5	0.57	(-0.17, 0.31)
agency	-40.23	923.12	< 0.001***	(-0.23, -0.21)

Notes. Two-sample t-tests with unequal variances. The analysis uses 518 matched month-year observations between November 1945 and December 1998. Socialist and ethnic corpora come from revolutionary periodicals and together represent non-institutional politics. Meetings of the Turkish Parliament represent institutional politics. *T* stands for t-statistic, *df* for degrees of freedom, and 95% CI for a 95 % confidence interval. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

I.3 Visualizations of auxiliary indicators of action-language

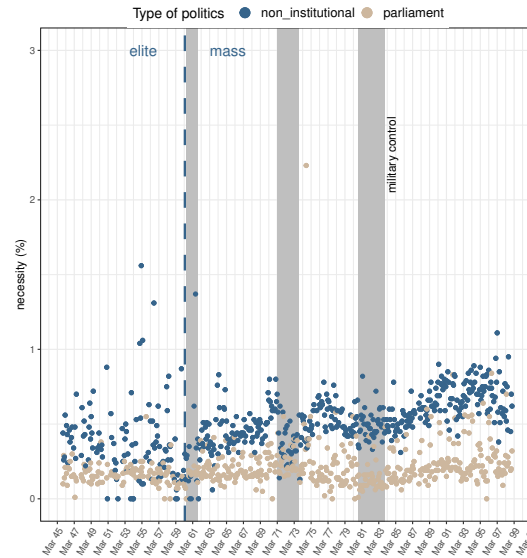
The figures use the same data structure as Table I2. In all figures, elite and mass refer to the support base of non-institutional politics. Gray shaded areas denote periods of military control that end with the next general election: May 1960–October 1961, March 1971–October 1973, and September 1980–November 1983.

Figure I1: Verbs denoting potential



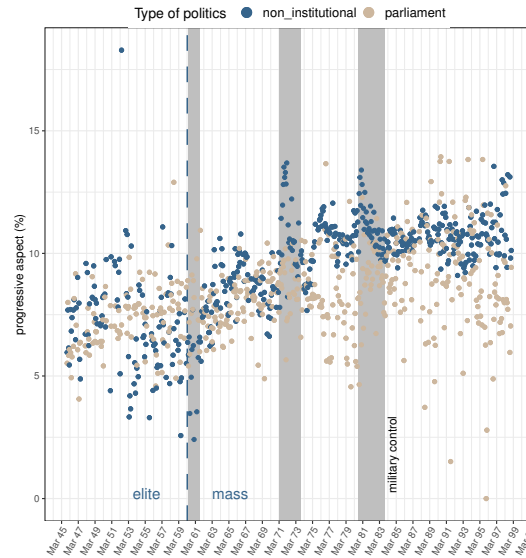
Notes. See the opening paragraph of Appendix I.3 for data structure, support categories, and shaded-period definitions.

Figure I2: Verbs denoting necessity



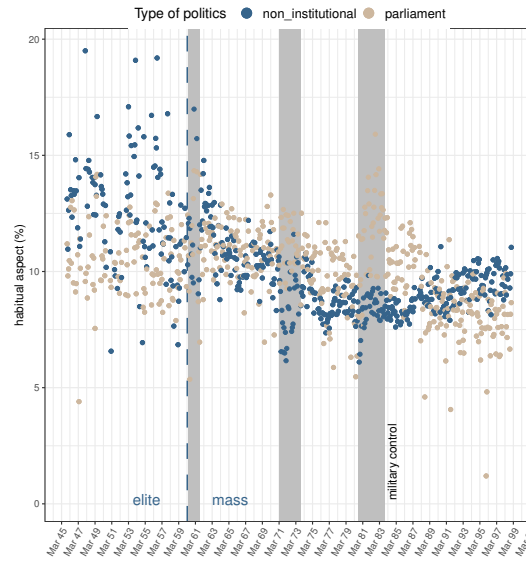
Notes. See the opening paragraph of Appendix I.3 for data structure, support categories, and shaded-period definitions.

Figure I3: Verbs denoting progressive aspect



Notes. See the opening paragraph of Appendix I.3 for data structure, support categories, and shaded-period definitions.

Figure I4: Verbs denoting habitual aspect



Notes. See the opening paragraph of Appendix I.3 for data structure, support categories, and shaded-period definitions.

J Action-language: external validity

J.1 Verb use by the Ku Klux Klan and the U.S. Congress

Table J1: Comparing total verb density in the U.S. Congress and Klan publications

t-test specification	<i>t</i>	<i>df</i>	<i>p-value</i>	95% CI
one-sided, var unequal	8.25	82.46	< 0.001***	(1.02, Inf)
two-sided	8.25	82.46	< 0.001***	(0.97, 1.59)
verb (%)	9.69	80.14	< 0.001***	(0.59, 0.90)
auxiliary verb (%)	5.55	87.99	< 0.001***	(0.34, 0.72)

Notes. Both corpora cover December 1924–December 1931, yielding 45 monthly observations for Congress and 84 for the Kourier. Means reported in [section 6.2.3](#) use all available months for each corpus; the tests use the 45 months in which Congress was in session and a monthly issue of the Kourier was available. Total verb density (%) is the sum of verb (%) and auxiliary verb (%). *T* stands for t-statistic, *df* for degrees of freedom, and 95% CI for a 95 % confidence interval. Significance levels: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Appendix References

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